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WITH TENSIONS HIGH OVER HORMUZ

US envoys arrive in Qatar for meetings on Iran

DUBAI: Two US envoys arrived in Qatar on Tuesday for talks with mediators about the implementation of an initial deal to end the war in Iran, an official said.

The visit by Steve Witkoff, US President Donald Trump's special Mideast envoy, and Jared Kushner, his son-in-law, comes after a weekend of cross-fire in the Persian Gulf over efforts to reopen the Strait of Hormuz to shipping traffic.

The envoys won't be having direct negotiations with Iranian diplomats while in Qatar's capital, Doha, said Majed al-Ansari, a spokesman for Qatar's Foreign Ministry.

Instead, mediators are working for the time being as go-betweens for the talks, which won't include any high-level officials, he added.

The US and Iran have held indirect negotiations before. However, the two previous



The envoys won't be having direct negotiations with Iranian diplomats

rounds collapsed and preceded the 12-day war Israel launched against Iran in 2025 and this year's war, launched jointly by the US and Iran on Feb 28.

Iran is also sending a delegation to Qatar this week. Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmail Baghaei said Tuesday that Iran has had no plans for a meeting with the American side at any

level in the coming days.

"What will take place in Doha tomorrow is a discussion with the Qatari side about implementing parts of the memorandum of understanding, including the release of Iran's blocked assets," Baghaei told journalists at his own briefing.

It is possible the two sides could exchange messages through the Qatari mediators.

Highlights

- » Mediators are working for the time being as go-betweens for talks
- » The US and Iran have held indirect negotiations before
- » It is possible the two sides could exchange messages through the Qatari mediators

through the Qatari mediators. The US and Iran agreed to an interim deal earlier this month that calls for Tehran to dilute its stockpile of enriched uranium.

It also waives US-backed oil sanctions on the country, calls for free traffic through the Strait of Hormuz and gives each side 60 days to hammer out broader agreements. AGENCIES

UK PM unveils defence funds to boost drone warfare capabilities

LONDON: Britain's caretaker Prime Minister, Keir Starmer, on Tuesday unveiled a major defence spending plan with a focus on boosting the country's drone warfare capabilities as his leadership legacy.

In one of his final big-ticket policy interventions after he announced his resignation last week, Starmer said the 'Defence Investment Plan' will be backed by 298 billion pounds of investment across the next four years.

He also tabled 15 billion pounds of additional spending in the wake of criticism from within his Cabinet over inadequate funds to ensure the UK was fully equipped to fight modern-day wars with cutting-edge abilities.

"This record investment puts the security of the British public first, transforming our armed forces and giving them the funding and equipment they need to fight and defend our nation," said Starmer. AGENCIES

Cuba's top diplomat says talks with US showing 'no progress'

HAVANA: Cuba's foreign minister said on Tuesday that talks initiated earlier this year with long-time foe the United States had stalled, leaving little hope for an end to U.S. sanctions that have laid siege to the island's ailing economy.

Top diplomat Bruno Rodriguez told reporters that U.S. sanctions were "causing deaths" in Cuba as the island's economy collapses and severe shortages of food, fuel, medicine and electricity make life nearly unbearable for the island's approximately 9 million residents.

"Talks between Cuba and the US show no progress," Rodriguez said at a press conference in Havana. "The conduct of US government delegations — generally respectful — has been accompanied by constant threats against Cuba, the application of coercive measures, and offensive statements regarding our country's independence."

"Despite this, Cuba remains open to dialogue and the peaceful resolution of differ Bruno Rodriguez ences, based



Cuba's foreign minister Bruno Rodriguez

on mutual respect and non-interference in Cuba's internal affairs."

The US State Department did not immediately respond to a request for comment on the foreign minister's statement.

The U.S. has called Cuba's government a national security threat and says sanctions are necessary to force a change in the island's government, a long-time aim of U.S. policy towards Cuba.

Cuba, 90 miles off the shores of the Florida Keys,

has long maintained it is not a threat to the United States.

United Nations experts have previously called the U.S. fuel blockade, implemented in January, "illegal" and a violation of the human rights of all Cubans.

U.N. Debate Rodriguez also said the U.S. State Department was also "pressuring and intimidating" United Nations member states to put off an upcoming floor debate over the U.S. blockade of the communist-run island. AGENCIES

Congo bans gatherings in areas far from Ebola outbreak

KINSHASA: Opposition and civil society groups are protesting Congo's new ban on public demonstrations and mass gatherings in the capital and other areas far from the country's deadly Ebola outbreak, alleging that the decision aims to limit freedom of speech.

The decision announced over the weekend came as the outbreak of a type of Ebola with no approved treatment or vaccine continues to grow, with 1,307 people infected and 377 dead across three provinces in eastern Congo. It could be the worst Ebola outbreak yet. Congo's Ministry of Interior on Saturday said gatherings and demonstrations were forbidden in the provinces of Kinshasa, Tshopo, Haut-Uele and Bas-Uele as fears grow about the outbreak spilling into new areas. None of the provinces has any confirmed cases.

Separately, the mayor of Goma, eastern Congo's

largest city and now under the control of the Rwanda-backed M23 rebel group, also banned public gatherings and demonstrations, including celebrations linked to sports events, on Monday. Congo is in its first World Cup in over half a century.

Congo's political opposition has denounced the ban as unconstitutional. Prince Epenge, the spokesperson for the Lamuka coalition, has said the ban aims to prevent a planned demonstration in the capital, Kinshasa, early next month. The protest is against proposed constitutional changes that would allow Congo's President Felix Tshisekedi to run for a third term. Civil society organisations also condemned the ban in a statement on Monday, citing freedom of speech and freedom of assembly.

In a televised address, Tshisekedi announced a \$319 million response plan to the Ebola outbreak. AGENCIES

Venezuela quakes: Aid workers warn of infectious diseases, overwhelmed hospitals

The death toll surpasses 1,700, new bodies still being hauled out from rubble

LA GUAIRA: Aid groups warned on Tuesday that Venezuela's fragile healthcare system is being pushed to its limits nearly a week after two powerful earthquakes, with damaged and understaffed hospitals overwhelmed by the injured and deteriorating conditions in the disaster zone, causing infectious diseases to spread.

The scores of international and domestic teams across Venezuela remain focused on the search for survivors, with the government death toll surpassing 1,700 and new bodies still being hauled out from the rubble.

But a humanitarian crisis is already unfolding among the living. United Nations agencies expressed concern about the health effects of thousands of displaced people sleeping for days in the open or in crowded, unsanitary shelters.

Venezuelan officials say that more than 15,800 people



Residents search through the rubble of a building that collapsed in the earthquakes in La Guaira on Tuesday

AP/PTI

have been affected by the earthquakes — a figure that reflects the official number of displaced people, UN refugee

agency spokesperson Carlotta Wolf said on Tuesday. Suddenly, homeless Venezuelans are sleeping in cars, parks and

elsewhere without adequate emergency shelter available.

Wolf said that number would continue to rise. AGENCIES

Pak: 14 children killed as roof of tuition centre collapses

LAHORE: At least 14 Pakistani schoolchildren were killed and 20 others injured when the roof of a private tuition centre operating from an under-construction building collapsed in Lahore on Tuesday, police said.

More than 30 children, aged between seven and 13 years, were attending classes at the academy, located in the densely populated Kahna Nau area, when the roof caved in, trapping them under the debris.

"So far, 14 bodies of children

have been recovered from the debris," Lahore Deputy Inspector General (DIG) Operations Faisal Kamran told reporters.

Twenty injured children and a female teacher were shifted to the hospital, police said, adding that the deceased include seven girls and as many boys.

"A part of the building was under construction and labourers were busy at work when the roof collapsed. We

'A part of the building was under construction and labourers were busy at work when the roof collapsed. We have arrested the contractor'

have arrested the contractor," Kamran said.

Later, the Lahore Police in a statement said the house owner has also been taken into custody as part of the initial investigation.

Punjab Health Minister Khawaja Imran Nazir said rescue teams have completed the operation.

Lahore District Education Authority Chief Executive Officer Tariq Mahmood said the building housed a private tuition centre being run by a woman resident of

the locality.

A statement by the Edhi Foundation, which also took part in the rescue operation, said the roof of the academy in the residential building in Basti Eid Gah locality "collapsed suddenly".

"The bodies of the deceased were shifted to the morgue at General Hospital," the NGO said, adding that the injured have been shifted to the hospital, where their condition was stated to be stable. AGENCIES

Ghana sued over third-country deportation deal with US

ACCRA: An international coalition of human rights lawyers and advocates sued Ghana on Tuesday, accusing the government of forcing deportees from the US back to the home countries they had fled in violation of their rights.

It's the latest legal case targeting an African country over a deal it signed with the Trump administration to accept deportees who aren't its own

citizens. The lawsuit was filed at a regional court, the Community Court of Justice of the Economic Community of West African States. The coalition includes the Global Strategic Litigation Council, a network of lawyers and advocates.

It's the first case ever brought under a 1979 regional treaty that guarantees free movement across West Africa. The case represents 27 people

among the at least 60 the US has deported to Ghana since September 2025 as part of an agreement between the governments. Ghana agreed to take in deportees, hold them and arrange their onward removal, despite most of them having received orders of protection by US judges against being deported to their home countries, according to a statement by the coalition. AGENCIES

Nepal: Two Indians arrested for alleged theft, looting pilgrims

KATHMANDU: Two Indian nationals were arrested here on Tuesday for allegedly carrying out thefts and looting pilgrims, Nepal Police said. The accused were identified as Ranjit Chaudhary, 34, and Shanti Chamar, 45, both residents of Gorakhpur in Uttar Pradesh.

They were currently staying in Nepal's Bhaktapur district, and were arrested from the Pashupatinath Temple area here, according to a police statement. Police alleged that the duo had been involved in stealing valuables from pilgrims visiting the temple as well as from people travelling on public transport.

During the operation, police recovered 12 gold ornaments, including earrings, a bracelet and a mangalsutra, besides 11 silver ornaments comprising rings, coins, bracelets and lockets. Cash amounting to Nepalese Rupees 115,500 and Indian Rupees 80,000, six mobile phones, two Indian PAN cards and one Aadhaar card were also seized from their possession, the statement said. AGENCIES

'Americans' pride in US history, democracy drops & fewer are proud to be American'

Much of the falling positivity comes from Democrats in the United States

WASHINGTON: Americans have grown less proud of their country's history or the way its democracy works over the past decade, according to a new AP-NORC poll.

Americans' pride in the US on several key attributes has dropped since 2017 — including the nation's military and its political influence around the globe — according to the survey from The Associated Press-NORC Centre for Public Affairs Research. This poll was conducted in April, as the United States and Iran fought over the Strait of Hormuz in a prolonged war that started with the US and Israel launching strikes on Iran. New Gallup polling also finds that only 53 per cent of US adupers centils are "extremely" or "very" proud to be an American, the lowest reading in the trend dating back to 2001.

The findings point to a broad decline in patriotic sentiment over a tumultuous period that included most of President Donald Trump's first term, the



The US Capitol being seen through fog behind the ferris wheel at the Great American State Fair in Washington

AP/PTI

COVID-19 pandemic and rising inflation that contributed to a backlash against President Joe Biden. That timeframe also covers Trump's return to the White House, where he's taken more aggressive actions on immigration and issues abroad.

Much of the falling positivity comes from Democrats, who have become increasingly disenchanted with the country since Trump's first term.

At the same time, most US

adults say that being an American is "extremely" or "very" important to their identity, highlighting an enduring connection, even as some become increasingly critical of the country's past or the govern-

THE POLL WAS CONDUCTED IN APRIL, AS THE UNITED STATES AND IRAN FOUGHT OVER THE STRAIT OF HORMUZ

ment's current actions.

Americans' pride in the way democracy works in the US has declined 14 percentage points, falling from 42 per cent in February 2017 to 28 per cent now. In addition, Americans' pride in their armed forces has dropped 19 percentage points since 2017, and pride in the US's history has declined 14 percentage points. In each case, the drop is largely driven by Democrats, with some movement among independents as well. Karla Galdamez — a 48-year-old Democrat who used to teach US history — believes America has regressed under the Trump administration. AGENCIES

World Briefs

DEAD BABY FOUND IN TOILET AT MUSIC FESTIVAL IN MICHIGAN

ROTHBURY: The body of a baby was found inside a portable toilet at a music festival in rural Michigan over the weekend, prompting police to ask the public for help. The child was less than a month old, Michigan State Police said, and its remains were discovered by a bathroom company employee during routine maintenance Sunday morning, the last day of the Electric Forest festival. Authorities have not said how the baby died, whether it was a boy or a girl, or whether a parent, guardian or person connected to the baby has been identified. An autopsy was completed on Monday, and police would provide updates once those results are reviewed by investigators, Michigan State Police Lt. Pat Agema said. So far, the death has not been classified as a homicide, Agema said Tuesday.

EXHIBITION ON SANSKRIT, SIDDHAM SCRIPT HELD IN BEIJING

BEIJING: An exhibition showcasing Sanskrit calligraphy and the Siddham script, highlighting the shared cultural and civilisational heritage of India and China, was held in Beijing, officials said on Tuesday. Titled "Sanskrit Ink in the Courtyard", the exhibition was organised by the Beijing-based Courtyard Institute and featured works by Sanskrit enthusiasts from diverse backgrounds, the Indian Embassy here said in a social media post. The exhibition celebrated the beauty of Sanskrit and the Siddham script, reflecting centuries of cultural and intellectual exchange.



CITY: Pg 7

SIR kicks off in Capital; CM calls it ‘yajna of democracy’



NATION: Pg 11

VB-G RAM G Act to come into force from today, govt all ready for rollout



FILM: Pg 14

‘Incredibly humbling and deeply fulfilling’

PM Modi reviews governance reforms as Cabinet reshuffle speculation grows

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: Amid speculation over a possible reshuffle of the Union Council of Ministers, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday interacted with secretaries of all Union ministries to review governance reforms, improve inter-ministerial coordination and discuss measures to strengthen public service delivery.

The meeting was held at the newly built Prime Minister's Office complex, Seva Teerth, in New Delhi. According to officials, discussions centred on two themes: deregulation and other reforms to improve ease of doing business and ease of living, and promoting Aatmanirbharta (self-reliance).

During the interaction, secretaries outlined the major initiatives undertaken by their respective ministries in line with these priorities. They also highlighted efforts to translate the Prime Minister's vision into actionable outcomes, discussed sector-specific challenges and presented future strategies to improve governance and service delivery. Sources said the presentations **Continued on P8**

US SC blocks Trump’s bid to end birthright citizenship

Upholds birthright citizenship under the 14th Amendment

ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON: A divided Supreme Court on Tuesday upheld a broad conception of birthright citizenship, rejecting President Donald Trump's executive order declaring that children born to people who are in the United States illegally or temporarily are not American citizens.

The justices relied on a long-settled understanding of the 14th Amendment, adopted after the Civil War, and more recent federal laws in ruling that anyone born in the country, with very limited exceptions, is a citizen.

“Citizenship, then and now, was the right to have rights-to freely participate in our political community. The Framers of the Fourteenth Amendment extended that promise to every free-born person in this land,” Chief Justice John Roberts wrote for the court,



citing congressional debate over the amendment, “We keep that promise today.”

Three conservative justices would have allowed the restrictions to take effect.

“The Court today takes the extraordinary step of holding facially unconstitutional the President's Order excluding from citizenship the children of foreign temporary visitors and illegal

aliens,” Justice Clarence Thomas wrote in a 91-page dissent, more than three times as long as Roberts' opinion. “In doing so, the Court adds to the sad history of the **Continued on P8**

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Court rejects Trump’s executive order restricting automatic citizenship
- » Majority reaffirms long-standing interpretation of the Constitution
- » Children born in US remain citizens with limited exceptions
- » Chief Justice Roberts authored the majority opinion
- » Three conservative justices dissented from the ruling
- » Justice Thomas called the decision constitutionally flawed
- » Lower courts had already blocked Trump’s order nationwide
- » Trump signed the order on his second-term first day
- » Order targeted children of undocumented and temporary migrants
- » Restrictions also covered students and green card applicants’ children

IN PHONE CONVERSATION WITH IRANIAN PRESIDENT

PM Modi calls for lasting peace and safe navigation through Strait of Hormuz

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday spoke with Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian over the phone to discuss the latest developments in West Asia, with both leaders reviewing recent progress in regional peace efforts and the way forward.

According to a statement issued by the Prime Minister's Office (PMO), President Pezeshkian briefed Modi on the current situation in the region and the ongoing diplomatic process.

During the conversation, Modi welcomed the understanding reached in the negotiations and said India continues to believe that disputes should be settled through dialogue and diplomacy. He also underlined the need for sustained efforts to secure lasting peace and stabil-



ity in West Asia.

The prime minister reiterated the importance of keeping the Strait of Hormuz open for global trade, saying freedom of navigation through the strategic waterway remains vital for both India and the world. He also stressed the need to safeguard maritime commerce.

Sharing details of the conversation on X, Modi wrote, “Spoke with the President of Iran, **Continued on P8**

Monsoon session of Parliament likely from July 20

NEW DELHI: The Monsoon session of Parliament is likely to commence from July 20 and is expected to go on for three weeks, officials said on Tuesday.

The Cabinet Committee on Parliamentary Affairs (CCPA) is yet to take a final decision.

Usually, Monsoon and Winter sessions have 20 sittings and are spread over four weeks. But there have been precedents

of shorter sessions.

The Monsoon session comes after the ruling BJP's victories in West Bengal, Assam and Puducherry.

The rebellion in TMC and Shiv Sena (UBT) will also play out in the forthcoming session.

A decision by Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on the demands of 20 TMC and six Shiv Sena (UBT) MPs seeking

recognition as separate groups is awaited.

In the Rajya Sabha, after newly elected and re-elected MPs took oath, the political numbers further tilted in favour of the ruling NDA.

The last session ended in disappointment for the government as a Constitution amendment bill to implement reservation for women in leg-

islatures in 2029 and increase the number of seats of the Lok Sabha was defeated in the Lower House.

The government is now redrafting the bill to possibly increase Lok Sabha seats of all states uniformly by 50 per cent.

The population-linked increase in seats has been a major concern for southern parties. **MPPOST**

Quick News

ISM 2.0: CENTRE APPROVES RS 1.25 LAKH CRORE OUTLAY

NEW DELHI: The Expenditure Finance Committee under the Finance Ministry has approved a Budget proposal allocating Rs 1.25 lakh crore for the India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) 2.0, marking a major step in the country's efforts to strengthen its semiconductor manufacturing ecosystem, according to sources.

The proposal, which will now be placed before the Union Cabinet, carries a significantly higher outlay than the Rs 76,000 crore allocated under the first phase of the India Semiconductor Mission.

Announced in the Union Budget 2026-27, ISM 2.0 aims to expand India's chip manufacturing capabilities by **Continued on P8**

MSC TO BUY 49% STAKE IN ADANI'S VIZHINJAM PORT FOR \$1.4 BILLION

NEW DELHI: Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone (APSEZ) on Tuesday announced that Switzerland-based Mediterranean Shipping Company (MSC), the world's largest shipping transport and logistics group, will acquire a 49 per cent stake in its Vizhinjam port in Kerala for about USD 1.4 billion.

The MSC will make the acquisition through its arm, Terminal Investment Limited (TiL). As per the deal, TiL will invest USD 1.397 billion, equivalent to its proportionate 49 per cent share of the total deal value of USD 2.85 billion.

In a statement, APSEZ said the partnership marks the largest foreign private investment in Indian port infrastructure **Continued on P8**

SIT finds management failure in Ram Temple row

Top functionaries under scanner, police record Champat Rai's statement

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: The Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing alleged irregularities in the Ram Temple management has found evidence of administrative lapses and supervisory failures and has not given a clean chit to any office bearer, employee or person associated with the temple's functioning, sources said.

A senior official of SIT told this reporter that the investigation agency has flagged the roles of senior trust functionaries, including General Secretary Champat Rai, trustee Anil Mishra and construction aide Gopal Rao, while investigations into allegations of commission and irregular land transactions are still underway.

“We have not given clean chit to any senior official. We have interrogated Champat Rai and have issued notice to 80 Ram Mandir Trust office bearers including Anil Mishra. We have found a trail of money,” he said.

Investigators have already recorded statements of several witnesses and are collecting documen-



tary evidence. Gopal Rao, against whom multiple allegations have surfaced, also remains under the scanner.

“The SIT is separately investigating allegations that trustee Anil Mishra sought a 40 per cent commission in certain dealings. Allegations of irregularities in land purchases and sales involving Champat Rai are also under scrutiny as one of the close aides of Rai purchased a large chunk of land and, the same day, sold it at an exorbitant rate,” official said.

The SIT submitted its preliminary report to the Uttar Pradesh government on June 23 and made a series of recommendations, including the registration **Continued on P8**

SC orders status quo on HC ruling on enhanced ethanol allocation

MPPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Tuesday ordered status quo on a Karnataka High Court direction requiring oil marketing companies (OMCs) to reconsider increasing ethanol allocation to a dedicated manufacturer for the Ethanol Supply Year (ESY) 2025-26, after the Centre argued that altering finalised allocations could disrupt the country's nationwide ethanol blending programme. The government told the court that reopening the allocation process at this stage could trigger similar claims from other suppliers, affect the **Continued on P8**

TAKEAWAYS

- » India records fifth-driest June since 1901 with 40% rainfall deficit
- » Country received 99.5 mm rain against normal 165.3 mm in June
- » Central India records worst rainfall deficit at 50%
- » Gujarat posts highest state rainfall shortfall at 82%

- » Delayed monsoon slows kharif sowing across several states
- » Heatwave conditions persist across north and central India through June
- » IMD forecasts below-normal July rainfall at 94% of long-period average
- » July long-period average rainfall stands at 280.4 mm

above normal over most parts of the country.

Addressing a press conference on Tuesday, the IMD said India received 99.5 mm

of rainfall between June 1 and June 30 against the normal 165.3 mm, making June 2026 the fifth-driest June since records began **Continued on P8**

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E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-E-2026-155	
Description of work: Jhansi Division: Provision of back wall of PF1, Full Length with increased of PF1, Increased of COP length on PF1 & 2, New waiting hall on PF1 at Tikamgarh (TKMG) station.	
Approx Cost: ₹ 48192649.68	Earnest Money: ₹ 963900.00
Date of closing Tender: 23.07.2026 at 15.00 hrs.	
Date of completion/period from issue of acceptance letter: 10 Months	
* Tender online can be submitted up to 15:00 hrs on 23.07.2026 * For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website	
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₹51+ lakh crore transferred directly to bank accounts of beneficiaries through DBT



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Startup India and Atal Innovation Mission driving deep-tech growth



12 semiconductor plants taking shape

“ Digital India means Government at your doorstep, on your mobile phone. Digital India means curbing corruption. Digital India means ensuring that even the poorest receive their rightful benefits. ”

– Prime Minister Narendra Modi



MONSOON WAIT MAY END BY JULY 4, SAY WEATHER EXPERTS

Capital braces for monsoon as ‘feels like’ temp hits 53.5 deg C

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi continued to swelter through what could be the last lap of summer on Tuesday, with weather experts saying that the southwest monsoon is likely to make its onset over the national capital around July 3 or 4 as favourable conditions develop across northern India.

Mahesh Palawat, Vice President, Skymet Weather, said the seasonal monsoon trough has currently extended from Punjab to the north Bay of Bengal, while the monsoon has already advanced over many parts of Uttar Pradesh, most of Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh and Ladakh, and some more parts of Madhya Pradesh.

A cyclonic circulation persists over the north Bay of Bengal, and under its influence, a low-pressure area is expected to develop and move westwards, triggering widespread rain activity across the Indo-Gangetic plains from Bihar to north Punjab over the next few days, he added.

He further said that rain activity is expected to intensify over Punjab, Haryana, Delhi and north Rajasthan by July 2 or 3, with the monsoon likely to



Workers assemble air coolers at a market amid heatwave conditions PTI

reach Delhi and adjoining areas around July 3 or 4.

“The seasonal trough extends from Punjab to the north Bay of Bengal. Monsoon has already advanced over many parts of Uttar Pradesh, most parts of Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh and Ladakh, and some more parts of Madhya Pradesh,” he said.

Explaining the delay, Palawat said the humid easterly winds from the Bay of Bengal, which are essential for sustained monsoon rainfall, have not yet reached Delhi.

“The monsoon generally advances along the seasonal trough, which currently

stretches from Punjab to the Bay of Bengal over a distance of nearly 1,500 kilometres. The easterly winds from the Bay of Bengal are expected to reach Delhi around July 3 or 4 along with the trough. Until then, the city is likely to receive only isolated spells of rain. Once these easterly winds set in and the trough becomes more favourable, monsoon activity will pick up significantly,” he added.

The trough acts as the backbone of the southwest monsoon. It is an elongated zone of low atmospheric pressure that draws moisture-laden winds from the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal deep into the

TAKEAWAYS

» ‘The monsoon generally advances along the seasonal trough, which currently stretches from Pb to the Bay of Bengal’

» ‘The easterly winds from the Bay of Bengal are expected to reach Delhi around July 3 or 4 along with the trough. Until then, the city is likely to receive only isolated spells of rain’

Indian mainland, helping organise widespread rainfall.

Even as the city looked ahead to the monsoon’s arrival, Delhi reeled under oppressive weather conditions, with the apparent, or “feels like,” temperature soaring to 53.5 degrees Celsius at 5.30 pm. However, the IMD said the city did not meet the criteria for a heatwave. The maximum temperature at Safdarjung, the city’s base station, settled at 40.5 degrees Celsius, 3.1 notches above normal.

Palam recorded 41.0 degrees Celsius, 3.2 notches above normal, while Lodhi Road recorded 40.1 degrees Celsius, 3.1 notches above

normal. Ridge was the hottest station at 41.5 degrees Celsius, 4.8 notches above normal, and Ayanagar recorded 40.1 degrees Celsius, 2.0 notches above normal.

Trace rainfall was recorded till 8.30 am at Safdarjung, Palam, Lodhi Road and Ayanagar, while Ridge did not receive any rain. Between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm, trace rainfall was recorded at Palam and Ayanagar, while no rainfall was recorded at Safdarjung, Lodhi Road and Ridge.

The minimum temperature at Safdarjung settled at 30.2 degrees Celsius, 2.3 notches above normal. Palam also recorded a minimum of 30.2 degrees Celsius, 2.4 notches above normal. Lodhi Road and Ayanagar recorded 31.2 degrees Celsius, 4.2 notches and 4.4 notches above normal, respectively, while Ridge recorded 29.3 degrees Celsius, 3.8 notches above normal.

The IMD said no heatwave was declared over Delhi as the prescribed criteria were met at only one station in the Haryana-Chandigarh-Delhi subdivision, whereas at least two stations are required for a heatwave declaration.

Couple ‘consume pesticide’; woman dies, man critical

NEW DELHI: A woman and her pet dog were found dead while her husband, a homeopathy practitioner, was admitted to hospital in critical condition after the couple allegedly consumed pesticide at their residence in Delhi’s Bindapur area, an official said on Tuesday.

The husband told police that the couple had consumed the poison together. Police suspect they attempted suicide due to depression. Preliminary inquiry has also revealed that the couple’s children live separately outside Delhi, officials said.

Bindapur police station received information about the suicide attempt around 2.49 am, he said.

On reaching the house in Indira Park, police found Jaspreet Kaur (55) dead, while her husband, Richhpal (56), was found in a semi-conscious state. Both were shifted to hospital, where Jaspreet was declared brought dead, while Richhpal was admitted to Deen Dayal Upadhyay Hospital for treatment.

A pet dog belonging to the couple was also found dead inside the house. According to police, preliminary inquiry revealed that the couple allegedly consumed pesticide on June 29 around 11.30 am in an apparent attempt to end their



“Richhpal told police that both he and his wife had consumed the substance together. Exact circumstances leading to the incident are still being verified”

lives. During questioning, Richhpal told police that both he and his wife had consumed the substance together, officials said. The exact circumstances leading to the incident are, however, still being verified.

Police have inspected the crime scene and initiated an investigation. The body has been sent for post-mortem, while forensic teams collected samples from the house as part of the probe. Further inquiry is underway, police added. MPOST

Court grants bail to CBI official who ‘stole Rs 1 lakh during raid’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court has granted bail to a CBI official accused of stealing Rs 1 lakh during a raid at the residence of a private individual. The officer was booked by the CBI under Section 305 (theft in a dwelling house) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). According to the prosecution, he allegedly stole the cash while serving as part of a CBI search team and hid it beneath the floor mat of a vehicle. An independent witness reportedly saw him conceal the money, which was later recovered. The prosecution also claimed the accused admitted his guilt before fellow CBI officials.

Granting bail on June 25, Special Judge Chhavi Kapoor observed that the investigation had been completed, all material witnesses examined and the electronic evidence seized and sent for forensic analysis. The court noted that the alleged stolen amount had been recovered and that the accused was neither a flight risk nor likely to hamper the investigation.

The court granted bail on a personal bond and surety of Rs 50,000 each, subject to conditions including remaining within Delhi-NCR, surrendering his passport and cooperating with the investigation.

OHE failure disrupts Delhi Metro services

NEW DELHI: Delhi Metro services on a section of the Blue Line were disrupted for more than an hour on Tuesday evening after an overhead equipment (OHE) failure affected operations between Anand Vihar and Vaishali stations.

According to the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), the disruption began at around 5.20 pm and normal services were restored by 6.43 pm after repair work was completed.

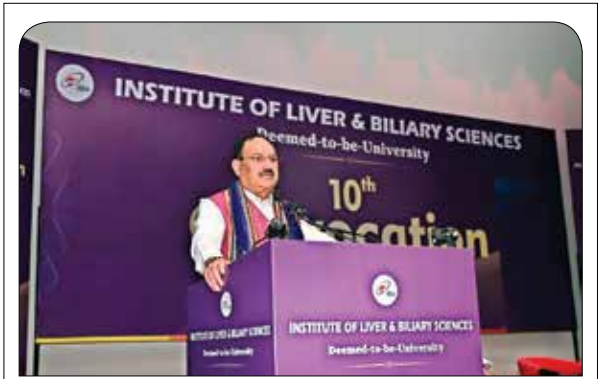
To facilitate restoration, train services between Anand Vihar and Vaishali were temporarily suspended. During the disruption, DMRC operated trains on a single line between Yamuna Bank and Anand Vihar to maintain connectivity for commuters travelling on the affected stretch.

Metro services on the Noida

Electronic City to Dwarka Sector 21 corridor continued to operate normally and were not impacted by the technical fault.

DMRC said technical teams were immediately deployed to rectify the overhead equipment failure, following which services resumed on the affected section. The corporation also said passengers were kept informed throughout the disruption through regular public announcements at metro stations and inside trains. These announcements provided updates on the temporary service changes and restoration efforts to help commuters plan their journeys.

The peak-hour disruption inconvenienced commuters, but single-line operations maintained partial connectivity until normal services resumed at 6.43 pm. MPOST



The Institute of Liver and Biliary Sciences (ILBS) marked its 10th Convocation in New Delhi on Tuesday, conferring degrees on 36 postdoctoral and eight PhD graduates. Union Health Minister J P Nadda lauded the institute’s contribution to liver care and urged graduates to expand access to specialised healthcare MPOST

Delhi-NCR hosp performs over 2,500 bone marrow transplants

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A Delhi-NCR hospital has crossed the milestone of performing more than 2,500 bone marrow transplants across adult and paediatric patients, underscoring advances in the treatment of blood cancers and complex blood disorders, according to a statement.

According to Fortis Memorial Research Institute (FMRI), Gurugram, the bone marrow transplant (BMT) programme has helped treat patients with conditions such as leukaemia, lymphoma, thalassaemia, sickle cell disease, immunodeficiency disorders, and other rare haematological diseases.

Advances in genomics, donor matching, cellu-

“Crossing 2,500 Bone Marrow Transplants is not merely a numerical milestone; it represents 2,500 lives touched & countless families given renewed hope”

lar therapies and personalised treatment protocols have significantly improved transplant outcomes and expanded access to the procedure over the past decade, the hospital said in a statement.

“Crossing 2,500 Bone Marrow Transplants is not merely a numerical milestone; it rep-

resents 2,500 lives touched and countless families given renewed hope,” said Dr Rahul Bhargava, Principal Director and Chief of Haematology, Haemato-Oncology and Bone Marrow Transplant at FMRI.

Dr Vikas Dua, Principal Director and Head of Paediatric Haematology, Haemato-Oncology and Bone Marrow Transplant, said bone marrow transplantation can be life-saving for children diagnosed with blood cancers, thalassaemia, aplastic anaemia and immune deficiency disorders.

The hospital said it plans to further strengthen its bone marrow transplantation, cellular therapy, genomics and precision medicine programmes to improve access and long-term outcomes for patients.

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 26-year-old Delhi Civil Defence volunteer has been arrested for allegedly impersonating a Delhi Police constable while wearing an official police uniform in North-East Delhi.

The accused, identified as Shahrulkh Khan, a resident of Loni in Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, was apprehended by the Anti Auto Theft Squad (AATS) of the North-East dis-

“He identified himself as a Delhi Police constable posted at Karawal Nagar PS”

trict following a tip-off that he was posing as a police officer near Jawahar Nagar Picket under the jurisdiction of Karawal Nagar Police Station.

Police said the accused, who was deployed as a Delhi Civil Defence volunteer at the SDM Office in Nand Nagri, was detained during

a raid on June 28.

During questioning, he allegedly identified himself as a Delhi Police constable posted at Karawal Nagar Police Station. Police are investigating the motive behind the impersonation and whether the uniform was used to obtain unlawful benefits or commit other offences. Further investigation is underway.

A Delhi Police constable’s uniform was recovered from

Sirsa orders drive to secure and develop vacant government land

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa on Tuesday chaired a high-level meeting to review the status of vacant government land in the Rajouri Garden Assembly constituency and directed departments to secure the sites, prevent encroachments and develop them for public use.

The meeting, attended by senior officials from the Revenue Department, civic agencies and the West Delhi district administration, reviewed land belonging to agencies including the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), Public Works Department (PWD), Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), Irrigation and Flood Control Depart-



ment, and Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC).

Officials noted that several vacant plots lacked boundary walls and had been encroached upon or were being used for dumping garbage and construction debris, posing health and environmental concerns.

Addressing the meeting, Sirsa said, “Government land is a valuable public asset and every inch of it must serve the people of Delhi. These lands should be utilised for public welfare by developing parking facilities, commu-

nity centres, Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, parks and other civic infrastructure, instead of being allowed to fall prey to encroachments or neglect.”

He further said, “Vacant government land cannot be allowed to become dumping grounds for garbage or construction debris. Every land-owning agency must ensure proper boundary walls, regular maintenance and timely removal of encroachments.”

The minister also asked officials to explore the creation of organised parking facilities and central road verges to improve traffic flow and reduce congestion. He directed all concerned departments to prepare a coordinated action plan for protecting and optimally utilising vacant government land in the constituency.

his possession. During interrogation, the accused allegedly admitted to impersonating a police officer.

An FIR has been registered under Sections 204 and 205 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) at Karawal Nagar Police Station. Police are investigating the motive behind the impersonation and whether the uniform was used to obtain unlawful benefits or commit other offences. Further investigation is underway.

Umar Khalid opens up on 6 yrs in jail, isolation and political climate

NEW DELHI: Student activist Umar Khalid has said nearly six years in prison have stripped him of both “humanity” and, at times, “sanity,” as he accused the Narendra Modi-led NDA government of presiding over a society where hate and misinformation have become normalised. In his first interview since being arrested in 2020 in connection with the larger conspiracy case linked to the Delhi riots, Khalid described the psychological toll of spending years in Delhi’s Tihar Jail without a trial.

“You even hear murmurs about yourself from fellow prisoners you shared meals with, calling you a terrorist behind your back. This propaganda dehumanises me in people’s eyes,” Khalid told The Guardian through family members

and friends because of communication restrictions.

“Humanity is a privilege that is not granted to people like me,” he said.

“Even those who sympathise with you, or portray you as someone larger than yourself, forget that I am a human being with my own share of vulnerabilities, fears and imperfections. And that these long years in prison have wreaked havoc on my mind and body and exacerbated all these anxieties within me.”

Khalid was arrested in September 2020 under anti-terror laws after being accused of being a “key conspirator” in the 2020 Delhi riots and plotting “violent regime change”. He has consistently denied the allegations, while the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has main-

tained that India’s judicial process is independent and his prosecution is unrelated to politics.

He said prison had not altered his views on the country’s political climate, expressing concern over what he described as the “normalisation and glorification of hate speech and genocidal language.”

“The process of India becoming a post-truth society is near complete,” he said.

Khalid also criticised what he called the silence of opposition parties and sections of civil society over the imprisonment of activists and dissidents.

“Six years down the line, I must say that I am really disappointed and even feel isolated,” he said. “This silence... emboldens this regime to go after further dissidents.” MPOST

CAMPUS TO FEATURE MODERN RESEARCH, SPORTS, HOSTEL INFRASTRUCTURE

Delhi govt panel approves construction of new Ambedkar Univ campus in Dheerpur

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government’s Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC) has approved the construction of the first phase of Dr B R Ambedkar University’s new campus at Dheerpur, paving the way for the long-pending expansion of the state university, according to an official document released on Tuesday.

The proposal, submitted by the Directorate of Higher Education, was approved during the fourth meeting of the EFC for the financial year 2026-27, chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on June 24.

The project will now be

placed before the Council of Ministers for final approval, subject to a series of conditions laid down by the committee.

The project envisages a total covered area of over 2.26 lakh square metres. The planning phase has been pegged at six months, while execution is expected to take 60 months. Expenditure has been phased over five financial years, beginning with Rs 200 crore in 2026-27 and ending with Rs 268.41 crore in 2030-31.

According to the EFC minutes, the revised project cost has been worked out at Rs 1,668.41 crore based on DPAR 2025, DSR 2023, at prevailing market rates and additional

“The 1st phase is expected to create facilities for around 5,400 students”

provisions, including contingencies, quality assurance, artwork, a 5-star GRIHA green rating and statutory charges.

The proposed campus will come up on a 20-hectare (2,00,000 square metre) plot in north Delhi’s Dheerpur. The project aims to expand access to quality higher education and provide modern academic and research infrastructure for nearly 8,000 students once fully

completed. The first phase is expected to create facilities for around 5,400 students.

The campus will include academic blocks, a central library, an auditorium, sports infrastructure, residential accommodation and hostel facilities. It has also been designed with sustainable features such as solar and geothermal energy systems, rainwater harvesting and wastewater recycling, according to the EFC minutes of the meeting.

During deliberations, the committee stressed that adherence to timelines would be critical and directed the executing agency to proactively secure all statutory clearances and

maintain stringent quality-control mechanisms, including third-party inspections wherever necessary. It also called for regular monitoring through a Project Monitoring Committee to prevent delays and cost overruns.

The EFC also suggested modifications to the campus master plan, including relocating the proposed multi-level car parking facility to preserve land for future expansion and reserving six to eight acres for additional hostel facilities.

The committee mandated a zero-waste campus, timely clearances, detailed planning and strict adherence to the sanctioned budget.

SIR kicks off in Capital; CM calls it ‘yajna of democracy’

Over 1.68 lakh forms distributed on day one; 7,605 digitised

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Enumeration forms of over 7,600 voters were digitised on day one of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Delhi on Tuesday, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta also filing her form and urging people to participate in the exercise to strengthen democracy.

The month-long door-to-door verification drive began with over 13,000 booth-level officers (BLOs) distributing enumeration forms and collecting the filled-up ones across the 70 Assembly segments in the capital.

A total of 1,68,291 forms were distributed on day one and 7,605 completed forms submitted by the voters were digitised by the BLOs, said a statement of Delhi Chief Electoral Officer's (CEO) office.

Delhi CEO Ashok Kumar appealed to all eligible voters to cooperate with the BLOs and accurately fill up the forms and submit it to them. The last date of filling up the SIR forms is July 29. In a post on X, the



Delhi chief minister said that she filled and submitted the enumeration form with details of herself and her family.

"Fill your enumeration form on time and submit it to your BLO. An accurate and up-to-date voter list is the foundation of a strong democracy. Let us fulfil our duty as conscious citizens and ensure our participation in this great 'yajna' of democracy," she said.

Delhi PWD minister Parvesh Sahib Singh also submitted the completed enumeration form from the New Delhi

constituency that he represents in the Assembly.

The opposition Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in Delhi alleged that the SIR process lacked transparency. The SIR process has been riddled with controversies, with opposition parties launching protests and approaching courts against it. However, the Supreme Court in May upheld the constitutional validity of the SIR process.

On Tuesday, 23 political parties, including AAP and Congress, sent a joint letter to Chief Justice of India Surya

HIGHLIGHTS

- » CM said she filled and submitted the enumeration form with details of herself and her family
- » 'Fill your enumeration form on time and submit it to your BLO. An accurate, up-to-date voter list is the foundation of a strong democracy. Let us fulfil our duty as conscious citizens...'

Kant on the SIR process, the role of the Election Commission and other election-related issues. Meanwhile, the BLOs in Delhi have been instructed to go door-to-door in the morning and evening hours, including on Saturdays and Sundays, when people are at home, officials said and added the door-to-door drive was largely smooth. Some voters, however, claimed that there were "hiccups" in filling up the forms.

Nitin, a 26-year-old resident in Mandir Marg area, said he wanted to verify some

details before filling it.

"My name is not in the 2002 voter list. I will speak to my father and check the Election Commission Website for the 2002 electoral roll before filling and submitting the form," he said. In Ansari Nagar (West), some voters said that there was "confusion" regarding documentation and details to be filled in the forms.

A BLO in the area explained to them that they should fill up the forms carefully, furnishing their details of 2002 SIR as well as their current voter list details. In an unauthorised settlement in Subhash Mohalla in North East Delhi, a BLO said that there were 15-20 houses carrying the same number because of division of larger plots into smaller ones.

The recognised political parties in Delhi are also taking part in the door-to-door survey through their booth level agents (BLAs) to assist people in filling up and submitting the forms. The national capital has 13,033 polling stations across seven Lok Sabha and 70 Assembly constituencies.

Delhi to allow private bodies to adopt 75 protected monuments

‘Twin heritage initiatives aim to improve conservation, tourism...’

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Cabinet has approved two new schemes aimed at conserving and promoting the capital's historical heritage, including a monument adoption programme that will allow private companies, public sector undertakings (PSUs), NGOs, trusts and other institutions to adopt 75 protected monuments for a period of five years.

Announcing the decision, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the initiatives are part of the government's 'Hamare Smarak, Hamara Gaurav' campaign and are designed to preserve monuments of local importance through public participation and public-private partnerships.

Under the Delhi Chief Minister Monument Adoption Scheme, organisations and individuals can become 'Monument Mitras' by adopting monuments under the Archaeology Department of the Delhi government. These monu-

ments are protected under the Delhi Ancient and Historical Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains (DAH-MASR) Act, 2004, and do not fall under the jurisdiction of the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI).

The Monument Mitras will be responsible for developing and maintaining visitor amenities such as cleanliness, lighting, security, light-and-sound facilities and other public services using their own resources. The government said this is expected to save around RS.4.5 lakh per monument annually. Any revenue generated through approved activities at the monuments must be reinvested in their upkeep and cannot be retained as private profit.

The adoption period will be five years and will be governed by a tripartite Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between the Delhi government, the land-owning agency and the Monument Mitra. Interested applicants will be required to submit an Expression of Interest along with a vision document outlining their development plans.

The Cabinet has also approved the Grant-in-Aid Scheme for Conservation, Restoration and Development Works, under which eligible trusts, NGOs, foundations, universities and govern-

ment institutions can receive financial assistance of up to Rs.2 crore for technical conservation and restoration of monuments.

Speaking on the initiative, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, "The Delhi Chief Minister Monument Adoption Scheme and the Scheme for Grant-in-Aid to Trusts/NGOs/Foundations/Institutions for Conservation, Restoration and Development Works of Monuments of the Government of NCT of Delhi serve different purposes. Under the Monument Adoption Scheme, Monument Mitras will use their own resources to provide and maintain cleanliness, security, lighting, light-and-sound facilities and other visitor amenities at the monuments. In contrast, under the Grant-in-Aid Scheme, the Government will provide financial assistance to eligible and specialised institutions for the core conservation, restoration and other technical conservation works of monuments."

The Delhi government said the schemes will generate employment, promote traditional crafts, strengthen local livelihoods and encourage public participation in heritage conservation. It added that 21 protected monuments are already being restored.

Worker falls to death from 2nd floor in Dwarka

NEW DELHI: A 35-year-old worker died after he allegedly fell from the second floor of a building while he was carrying out repair work at a house in southwest Delhi's Dwarka, police said on Tuesday.

The deceased was identified as Gurdev, a resident of Purnea district in Bihar.

According to police, information regarding the admission of an injured person at Indira Gandhi Hospital in Dwarka was received on Monday, following which a police team reached the hospital and collected his medico-legal case (MLC).

Police said Gurdev was brought to the hospital unconscious and unresponsive after he fell from a height of around 15 to 20 feet near Rosewood Apartments in Sector 13, Dwarka.

During inquiry, it was found that Gurdev was engaged in repair and maintenance work at the four-storey residential complex. He was working on the second floor when he lost balance, slipped and fell, they said.

He was later referred to Safdarjung Hospital for specialised treatment, but died during treatment. His body has been preserved in the hospital mortuary for post-mortem, they added. Police said the spot where Gurdev fell was inspected and photographed by the crime team.

MP05T

Besides incentives, new EV policy focuses on transport sector reforms: CM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Tuesday said Delhi's EV Policy 2026 goes beyond purchase incentives, providing a roadmap till March 2030 for structural reforms in the transport sector, expansion of charging infrastructure, a stronger institutional framework and phased electrification of different vehicle categories.

Approved by Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, the policy retains a purchase incentive of up to Rs 30,000 for electric two-wheelers and introduces an additional scrappage incentive of up to Rs 10,000. From April 1, 2028, only electric two-wheelers will be newly registered in Delhi, while all new auto-rickshaws registered from January 1, 2027, must be electric. The policy also offers

“Policy also offers incentives of up to Rs 1 lakh for N1 electric trucks, along with an add'l scrappage benefit”

incentives of up to Rs 1 lakh for N1 electric trucks, along with an additional scrappage

benefit of up to Rs 50,000. The first 1,000 N2 electric trucks will receive exemptions from no-entry restrictions. It also brings school transport under its ambit for the first time, setting a target of making 30 per cent of the school bus fleet electric by 2030.

Gupta said the new policy strengthens the institutional framework by creating a Delhi EV Apex Committee, a High-Powered Committee

and a dedicated EV Cell. It also introduces battery traceability from manufacturing to recycling through digital tracking, collection centres and a public-private partnership-based recycling system. Delhi Transco Limited has been appointed the nodal agency for expanding charging infrastructure, while funding will come from PM E-DRIIVE, the Delhi government's budget and pollution cess collections.

MCD rolls out 76 sanitation vehicles for Shahdara zones

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Tuesday announced the induction of 76 additional sanitation vehicles and equipment for Shahdara North and Shahdara South zones, while also reviewing infrastructure and redevelopment works across key areas of Shahdara South.

The sanitation expansion was flagged off at Mahavir Swami Park in Shastri Park by Union Minister of State for Road Transport and Highways and Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra in the presence of Mayor Praveesh Wahi, Deputy Mayor Monika Pant, Standing Committee Chairperson Satya Sharma, MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar and other civic officials.

According to the Corporation, 52 sanitation resources have been allocated to Shah-



dara North and 24 to Shahdara South. The new fleet includes tippers, hook loaders, battery-operated rickshaws, mini refuse collectors and mini dumpers aimed at improving waste collection and sanitation coverage, particularly in congested and narrow residential areas.

Addressing the gathering, Malhotra said the strengthening of sanitation infrastructure reflected the government's continued focus on making Delhi cleaner and reducing waste accumulation across the city. Civic leaders also called for greater public participation in

maintaining cleanliness standards. Separately, MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar carried out an extensive inspection of development works in Shahdara South and directed officials to expedite ongoing projects while ensuring adherence to quality standards.

During the visit, the Commissioner reviewed construction at the old zonal building in Vishwas Nagar and instructed officials to maintain close monitoring for timely completion. At Karkardooma Market, he directed the preparation of a comprehensive redevelopment plan covering roads, drainage, parking, lighting and civic infrastructure. The inspection also included Rishabh Vihar Market and the C&D waste site at Karkari Mor, where officials were asked to ensure environmental compliance, dust control and systematic waste management operations.

Delhi plans Rs 99.51-cr Sports Hostel, Rs 264.91-cr CM SHRI school upgrade

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government will build a sports hostel with an international-standard all-weather swimming complex and gymnastics hall at Pitampura at a cost of Rs 99.52 crore, besides undertaking repair, renovation and infrastructure upgradation of 75 CM SHRI schools for Rs 264.91 crore.

According to an Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC) document, the proposals have been processed by the Directorate of Education (DoE) and include the construction of the sports hostel at an estimated cost of over Rs 99.51 crore and systematic infrastructure upgradation of CM SHRI schools at Rs 264.91 crore.

The project includes the construction of ground plus seven-floor boys and girls' hostels, a long-span steel-struct-

“The earlier proposal had a fair-weather pool, which was considered inadequate for year-round use...”

tured covered swimming pool, a gymnastics hall, water supply and sanitation facilities, electrical installations, CCTV, fire-fighting and fire alarm systems, solar power generation, sewage treatment plant and other external development works.

It said the proposal was revised after officials observed the need for an all-weather swimming pool capable of hosting multiple aquatic activities simultaneously, including 50-metre and 25-metre competitions, water polo and other events.

The earlier proposal had a fair-weather pool, which was considered inadequate for year-round use and international-standard competitions.

According to the document, replacing the fair-weather pool with an all-weather international-standard facility, along with changes in design and scope, led to an increase in the project cost. The revised estimate also reflects additional statutory liabilities and the increase in GST from 12 per cent to 18 per cent.

It said the revised project cost includes Rs 75.20 crore for civil and electrical works and Rs 15.66 crore for specialised swimming pool components, and added that Rs 67.20 crore has already been sanctioned or released to the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation (DTTDC) for the project till 2025-26,

while Rs 50 crore has been allocated in the 2026-27 Budget, making sufficient funds available. In another proposal, the EFC recommended a Rs 264.91 crore plan for repair, renovation and systematic infrastructure upgradation of 75 CM SHRI schools in Delhi.

According to the official document, the schools were notified as "specified category" institutions under the DoE following a cabinet decision in May 2025 and a subsequent notification published in the Delhi Gazette in September 2025.

The project aims to improve education, safety and campus infrastructure through repairs, upgraded laboratories, libraries, sports facilities, accessibility features and fire safety systems. The 75 schools have been divided into five clusters, with works to be executed by PWD and selected PSUs.



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HUMAN RESOURCE MOBILITY FORUM

India signed mobility pacts with 26 countries, says Jaishankar

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India has signed 28 Migration and Mobility Partnership Agreements (MMPAs) or their equivalents with 26 countries and negotiations are underway with several others, External Affairs minister S Jaishankar said on Tuesday.

In his address at Human Resource Mobility Forum hosted by the Ministry of External Affair here, Jaishankar also underlined the importance of collective responsibility of nations to combat illegal migration and human trafficking, and asserted that “trusted mobility pathways” can contribute to stronger economies.

He said New Delhi views mobility as a “very important pillar” of international cooperation, adding these partnerships are based on “mutual benefit, shared responsibility, and long-



EAM S Jaishankar addresses the inaugural session of the Human Resource Mobility Forum, in New Delhi

term sustainability”.

When managed effectively, such partnerships create value for the source countries, the destination countries, and for employers, workers, and for the communities, the external affairs minister (EAM) said.

Highlights

» Jaishankar said New Delhi views mobility as a ‘very important pillar’ of international cooperation

» Jaishankar said that equally important is the collective responsibility of nations to combat illegal migration, exploitative practices, fraudulent intermediaries, and human trafficking

“We also recognise the need for bilateral collaborations in ensuring safe, orderly and legal migration. As on date India has signed 28 Migration and Mobility Partnership Agreements (MMPAs) or their equivalents with 26 countries and several others are currently under

negotiation,” he said.

Jaishankar said that equally important is the collective responsibility of nations to combat illegal migration, exploitative practices, fraudulent intermediaries, and human trafficking.

“These challenges compromise the credibility of legal mobility ecosystems and can place vulnerable individuals at risk,” the EAM said.

Several policymakers, industry leaders, employers, and practitioners have gathered for the Forum that seeks to offer opportunities to exchange ideas, learn from experiences, and explore new approaches towards mobility.

Jaishankar said the world is undergoing a “profound transformation”, and as part of that, demographic patterns are changing sharply across continents.

Technological innovation is reshaping industries at an unprecedented pace. Artificial intelligence, automation, digitalisation, and green transition are also redefining skills that are required for tomorrow’s economy, he said.

“But the challenges of yesterday also remain with us, be they of health, manufacturing, construction or agriculture. At the same time, societies are becoming increasingly interconnected, and the ability of nations to think creatively will significantly influence their prospects for future prosperity,” he underlined.

Human resource mobility therefore represents far more than the movement of people from one place to another. It is about “connecting aspirations with opportunities”, linking “talent with demand”

US SC blocks Trump’s bid to end...

Continued from Page 1
Fourteenth Amendment, which was designed and understood to secure equal rights for the freed blacks but has instead been repurposed for political projects that the Reconstruction Congress did not support.” The Republican president’s restrictions had been blocked by several lower courts and had not taken effect anywhere in the US

During arguments in April, both conservative and liberal justices questioned the order’s legality in a momentous case that was magnified by Trump’s unprecedented attendance in the courtroom. The case framed another test of Trump’s assertions of executive power that defy long-standing precedent for a court with a conservative majority and a robust view of presidential power that has largely ruled in his favour. In the notable exceptions when the court has not, Trump has responded with starkly personal criticisms of the justices.

The justices ruled on Trump’s appeal of a lower-court ruling from New Hampshire that struck down the citizenship restrictions.

The birthright citizenship order, which Trump signed on the first day of his second term, is part of his administration’s broad

immigration crackdown.

Birthright citizenship was the first Trump immigration-related policy to reach the court for a final ruling. The justices previously struck down global tariffs Trump had imposed under an emergency powers law that had never been used that way.

Trump reacted furiously to the late February tariffs decision, saying he was ashamed of the justices who ruled against him and calling them unpatriotic.

He also seemed to recognise the court was likely to rule against him on birthright citizenship, too, using his Truth Social platform to criticise “dumb judges and justices” and wealthy pregnant women from China and elsewhere who come to the US to give birth so their newborns will have American citizenship.

Trump’s order would have upended widely held views that the 14th Amendment confers citizenship on everyone born in the US, excluding only the children of foreign diplomats and those born to a foreign occupying force.

The amendment was intended to ensure that Black people, including former slaves, had citizenship, though the Citizenship Clause is written more broadly. “All persons born or

naturalised in the United States, and subject to the jurisdiction thereof, are citizens of the United States and of the State wherein they reside,” it reads.

In a series of decisions, lower courts have struck down Trump’s executive order as illegal. The decisions have invoked the high court’s 1898 ruling in Wong Kim Ark, which held that the US-born child of Chinese nationals was a citizen. The Trump administration argued that the common view of citizenship is wrong, asserting that children of non-citizens are not “subject to the jurisdiction” of the United States and therefore are not entitled to citizenship.

More than one-quarter of a million babies born in the US each year would have been affected by the executive order, according to research by the Migration Policy Institute and Pennsylvania State University’s Population Research Institute.

While Trump has largely focused on illegal immigration in his rhetoric and actions, the birthright citizenship restrictions also would have applied to people who are legally in the United States, including students and applicants for green cards or permanent resident status.

From Page 1

Cabinet reshuffle

also covered the functioning of ministries, progress on reform measures and people-centric initiatives. Modi stressed the need for a “whole-of-government” approach and called on ministries to break departmental silos to improve coordination, decision-making and implementation. He also urged wider use of the PM Gati Shakti platform for integrated planning, inter-departmental coordination and informed decision-making. The Prime Minister asked secretaries to focus on the tangible impact of government schemes on people’s lives.

The meeting comes about a month after Modi chaired a meeting of the Union Council of Ministers, where he said the government would leave no stone unturned to further improve ease of living, ease of doing business and create more opportunities for the youth. At that meeting, he had also outlined reform priorities aimed at achieving the goal of making India a developed nation by 2047, marking 100 years of Independence.

The latest interaction has also fuelled speculation over an imminent Cabinet reshuffle, with several media reports suggesting changes in the Union Council of Ministers could be announced soon. However, the government has made no official announcement. According to sources, the proposed exercise is linked to the BJP’s preparations for upcoming Assembly elections and the 2029 Lok Sabha elections. It is also expected to take into account the evolving dynamics within the National Democratic Alliance (NDA), with the possibility of greater representation for alliance partners in the Union Cabinet.

Sources said the Cabinet exercise could coincide with organisational changes in the BJP. Some Union ministers may be assigned party responsibilities, while party leaders could be inducted into the government. Younger leaders are also likely to be considered for roles in both the organisation and the Council of Ministers. The proposed reshuffle is also being viewed in the context of the government’s legislative agenda, including issues such as delimitation and the ‘One Nation, One Election’ proposal. According to sources, the government may realign ministerial responsibilities to better handle these priorities.

However, some government sources indicated that any Cabinet expansion or reshuffle could be deferred until after the Monsoon Session of Parliament.

Reports also suggest that the exercise may include the induction of new ministers, while some incumbents could be dropped or reassigned based on performance assessments. The BJP is also expected to focus on improving regional representation and increasing the participation of women, OBCs, SCs, STs and NDA allies in the Council of Ministers.

There has also been speculation over possible changes in portfolios, including the Education Ministry following recent controversies and a possible redistribution of responsibilities within the Finance Ministry. No official confirmation has been issued. According to sources, recent review meetings have gone beyond routine administrative assessments and included discussions on minis-

ters’ performance, policy implementation and public communication. The review process has also reportedly involved feedback from senior bureaucrats, political advisers and selected ministers, with a focus on infrastructure, employment generation, welfare schemes and improving coordination across ministries.

If carried out, the exercise would be the first major Cabinet reshuffle under the Modi 3.0 government. It is expected to focus on improving governance, rewarding performance, strengthening the NDA, expanding regional and social representation and preparing the BJP for the upcoming electoral cycle.

PM Modi calls

Dr Masoud Pezeshkian, on the recent developments in West Asia. Welcomed the progress made in the negotiations and expressed hope that continued efforts will lead to lasting peace in the region. Reiterated the importance of freedom of navigation in the Hormuz Strait for India and the World.”

Earlier, President Pezeshkian had invited Modi to attend the burial ceremonies of Iran’s late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, scheduled from July 5 to 9. According to reports, India is planning to send Bihar Governor Ata Hasnain and Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita as its representatives.

The latest diplomatic outreach follows the June 18 signing of the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding between the United States and Iran to restore peace in West Asia and advance negotiations on regional security and other contentious issues. The process was mediated by Pakistan and Qatar, which had first secured a two-week ceasefire on April 8 before it was extended until the talks concluded.

The agreement resulted in the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, through which nearly one-fifth of the world’s energy supplies normally pass. Shipping through the narrow waterway had been severely disrupted after joint US-Israel strikes on Iran on February 28 triggered retaliatory attacks, contributing to an energy crisis in several countries.

EC SIR row to CJI

the AAP and DMK, which have distanced themselves from the alliance. “Accordingly, a joint letter now signed by 23 political parties plus one Independent has been sent to the Hon’ble Chief Justice of India today,” he said.

The joint letter has been signed by Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Lok Sabha Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi, TMC chief Mamata Banerjee, RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav, Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren, J-K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, Left party leaders, and Independent MP Kapil Sibal, among others, sources said.

TMC leader Derek O’Brien said the letter has also been signed by the Aam Aadmi Party and the DMK.

“Good going from INDIA. And yes, @AamAadmiParty @arivalayam DMK also signed the joint letter to CJI,” he said on X. “The letter is a total teamwork by all INDIA bloc parties,” O’Brien told the media later. According to a senior Opposition leader privy to the developments, the letter is centred around the idea that when everything

else fails, Indian democracy looks towards the judiciary.

“It appeals to the conscience of the judiciary...The judiciary has to see what is happening in the country today. When everything else fails, who do we turn to?” the Opposition leader said.

The letter also refers to the role of the Election Commission of India, citing examples of how the SIR process has impacted people in different states, sources said.

The Congress and other Opposition parties have been questioning the EC over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

ISM 2.0

supporting semiconductor equipment, materials, indigenous intellectual property, resilient supply chains and other related components. The initiative is intended to help position India as a global semiconductor manufacturing destination.

Earlier, Union Electronics and IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw had said that ISM 2.0 would focus on indigenous chip design, production, attracting ecosystem partners and building skilled talent to support the sector’s long-term growth.

The government’s push comes as work under the first phase of the mission continues to gather pace. So far, 12 semiconductor manufacturing projects with a combined investment pipeline of about Rs 1.64 lakh crore have been approved. These include one semiconductor fabrication unit, two compound semiconductor fabrication units and nine packaging units.

Progress has also been recorded in semiconductor design. Under the Design Linked Incentive Scheme, 24 projects are receiving support, while 105 companies have gained access to advanced chip design tools. In addition, 23 design tapeouts have been completed at various foundries, including those using advanced process nodes, reflecting growing capabilities in chip design.

A senior IT Ministry official described the progress as the fulfilment of India’s “long-term dream” of establishing commercial semiconductor manufacturing in the country. The official said that two of the approved manufacturing projects have already been inaugurated for commercial production earlier this year, while CG Semi is expected to be inaugurated on July 4.

“CG Semi’s inauguration is scheduled for July 4... and then probably one or two more (will happen) before the end of this calendar year, so our dream of having commercial semiconductor manufacturing in the country has finally been achieved,” the official said, adding that more semiconductor projects are expected in the future.

The official also said India has emerged as an important player in the global technology landscape and has become “a voice to reckon with” in setting technology standards.

MSC to buy 49%

and strengthens Vizhinjam’s position as a major transshipment hub in the Indian Ocean region.

The company said the collaboration is expected to provide better cargo volume visibility and faster growth through higher traffic, including a larger share of cargo from Bangladesh that currently

depends on competing Southeast Asian transshipment ports. It is also expected to strengthen the Adani Group’s presence on East Africa trade routes and increase relay cargo volumes.

Commissioned in December 2024, Vizhinjam is India’s first deep-draft mega transshipment port. Located just 10 nautical miles from the East-West shipping route linking Europe, the Persian Gulf and the Far East, the port currently has a capacity of 1.6 million Twenty-foot Equivalent Units (TEUs). Expansion work is underway to raise capacity 3.5 times to 5.7 million TEUs by December 2028.

The port has a natural draft of 18 to 20 metres, a 2.9 km breakwater, an 800 metre berth, eight quay cranes and 24 fully automated yard cranes. It handled 1.3 million TEUs during FY26.

APSEZ Whole-time Director and CEO Ashwani Gupta said, “Vizhinjam Port has emerged as a premier transshipment hub and ramped up at an unprecedented pace, becoming the first Indian port to earn the unique distinction of crossing 2 million TEUs within 18 months of operations.”

TIL, part of the MSC Group, operates more than 100 container terminals across five continents, handling over 70 million TEUs annually. APSEZ also operates four international ports in Australia, Colombo, Israel and Tanzania.

Ram Temple

of an FIR. Acting on the report, police subsequently registered a case.

The investigation into the alleged theft of offerings is being carried out by the Circle Officer, Ayodhya, along with a dedicated team. Investigators are examining the bank accounts of the accused and scrutinising the role of every employee involved in counting the donations.

Officials said the final report is expected to clearly establish individual accountability and determine the nature of action to be taken against those found responsible.

Meanwhile, former Uttar Pradesh Director General of Police and former MP, O P Singh, said the issue goes beyond an ordinary theft case and has become a test of public faith.

“The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi temple is not merely a religious site. It is a symbol of the faith, trust and cultural consciousness of millions of Indians. Allegations of irregularities and theft in donations offered by devotees are not just a criminal incident but a test of public confidence,” Singh said.

He said that with an FIR now registered, the key question is not merely who stole the money but how the investigation should be conducted to establish the truth, punish those responsible and restore the faith of millions of devotees.

Since the consecration ceremony in January 2024, Ayodhya has witnessed an unprecedented influx of pilgrims. Public estimates suggest that the number of devotees visiting the temple has already run into several crores. During the 2025 Maha Kumbh, official figures showed that around 65 crore pilgrims took a holy dip in Prayagraj, and a substantial number are believed to have also visited Ayodhya for darshan of Ram Lalla.

Experts say that if even a modest amount was donated by each pilgrim, the cumulative donations could potentially run into thou-

sands of crores of rupees, although the actual figures can only be established through official records.

Singh said the scale of donations means the case cannot be treated as a routine theft. “This is fundamentally an economic offence,” he said, arguing that financial crimes often involve attempts to conceal money through bank accounts, investments, benami assets and other channels.

He said investigators should follow the principle of “Follow the Money” by scientifically examining every stage of the donation process, including the source of funds, collection, counting, banking, accounting and eventual utilisation.

“Where money has disappeared, there will invariably be some financial, documentary or digital trail,” he said. The former police chief also questioned whether an effective standard operating procedure was in place to manage the enormous flow of donations. He pointed out that major religious institutions around the world use digital accounting systems, high-quality CCTV surveillance, artificial intelligence-based monitoring, electronic access controls, automated currency counting machines and real-time audit systems.

“If crores of rupees are being received in donations every day, investing a few crores in modern security and accounting systems is not an expense but the necessary price of transparency, security and protection of public faith,” he said.

He added that if such systems were not adequately developed, the investigation should also examine where institutional shortcomings existed and why they persisted for so long.

SC orders

supply chain and delay implementation of the national policy. Later in the day, the Office of the Attorney General issued a clarification, saying certain media reports had incorrectly interpreted submissions made during the hearing regarding the 20 per cent ethanol blending programme.

A bench of Justices M M Sundresh and Sheel Nagu issued notice on a petition filed by Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (BPCL), challenging the Karnataka High Court’s June 23 order.

The High Court had directed BPCL, Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Limited and Indian Oil Corporation Limited to consider a representation by VINP Distilleries and Sugars seeking enhanced ethanol allocation for ESY 2025-26 before the tender process was finalised. The High Court observed that dedicated ethanol plants established under the government’s policy and bound by Long-Term Offtake Agreements (LTOAs) to supply ethanol exclusively to OMCs should not be denied the benefit of preferential allocation under those agreements.

Appearing for the Centre, Attorney General R Venkataramani told the Supreme Court that the ethanol allocation process had already reached finality in October 2025 and supply contracts had been concluded. He argued that changing the allocation for one supplier could have wider consequences for the national programme.

“The ethanol supply contracts had already been finalised in October 2025. Such petitions are pending before several high courts. This will impact the national policy,” he told

the court.

According to the Centre, ethanol allocations were finalised on October 17, 2025, and communicated to 378 suppliers for a total supply of about 1,050 crore litres. Of this, nearly 680 crore litres had already been supplied by June 18.

Venkataramani argued that increasing one supplier’s allocation would encourage similarly placed suppliers to seek the same relief, leading to multiple court cases and disrupting the allocation framework.

He also informed the court that BPCL, which coordinates the ethanol-blended petrol programme, had received cumulative supply offers of around 1,759 crore litres during the tender process.

Seeking an early resolution, the Attorney General said the Centre would file transfer petitions so that similar disputes pending before different high courts could be heard together by the Supreme Court before ethanol supply contracts come up for renewal in October.

Later, the Office of the Attorney General issued a press release stating that certain media reports had incorrectly suggested that the government’s 20 per cent ethanol-blended petrol (E20) Programme was “still an ongoing experiment” and that its impact would become clearer next year.

The clarification said the Attorney General’s submissions before the court were limited to informing the bench that similar petitions involving ethanol allocation to dedicated ethanol plants were pending before different high courts and that transfer petitions were being filed to avoid parallel proceedings and conflicting decisions.

It added that consolidating the cases before the Supreme Court would help ensure quicker resolution of the disputes so that ethanol supplies required to maintain 20 per cent blending with petrol throughout the year are not affected.

Separately, Venkataramani told India Today TV after the hearing that the 20 per cent ethanol blending target is a policy decision that is “not likely to change”, though the quantity of ethanol supplied to companies may vary depending on demand and other factors.

India achieved its target of 20 per cent ethanol blending in petrol in 2025, five years ahead of schedule, and OMCs began the nationwide supply of E20 petrol from April 1. The government has now set a target of increasing ethanol blending to 30 per cent by 2030.

The hearing comes days after the Union Oil Ministry rejected concerns over E20 fuel, saying the programme is safe, consumer friendly and economically beneficial. The ministry said claims that E20 fuel could invalidate vehicle insurance had been examined with stakeholders and found to be incorrect.

According to the ministry, ethanol blending has helped India save more than Rs 1.4 lakh crore in foreign exchange by reducing crude oil imports while also contributing to energy security, lower carbon emissions and cleaner mobility. The ministry said the programme would continue to be implemented in a safe, transparent and consumer-centric manner based on scientific evidence and stakeholder consultations. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

June disappoints

in 1901. Only 2009, with 87.6 mm, 1905 with 91.9 mm, 2014 with

92.8 mm and 1926 with 96.7 mm recorded lower June rainfall.

The prolonged dry spell affected agriculture across several states, with kharif sowing slowing because of inadequate soil moisture. North and central India also continued to experience heatwave conditions through much of the month as the monsoon struggled to move inland.

Central India recorded the largest rainfall deficit at 50 per cent, receiving 84.4 mm against the normal 170.3 mm. Northwest India ended June with a 31 per cent deficit, while the South Peninsula received 27 per cent less rainfall than usual.

Among states, Gujarat recorded the steepest shortfall at 82 per cent, followed by Chhattisgarh at 65 per cent and Jharkhand at 59 per cent. Uttar Pradesh received 50 per cent below-normal rainfall, Delhi 49 per cent, Bihar, Punjab and Maharashtra each 47 per cent below normal, while Kerala recorded a 34 per cent deficit.

Despite the weak June, the IMD said conditions have started improving. On June 30, the southwest monsoon advanced into more parts of Madhya Pradesh, the remaining areas of Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and Bihar, parts of Uttar Pradesh, most of Uttarakhand and parts of Himachal Pradesh and Ladakh.

IMD Director General of Meteorology Dr. Mrutyunjay Mohapatra said conditions remain favourable for the monsoon to advance over the next two to three days into more parts of Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh, the entire Daman and Diu region, the remaining parts of Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh and Ladakh, the whole of Jammu and Kashmir, most of Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi and Punjab, and parts of Rajasthan.

For July, however, the weather office has forecast rainfall at 94 per cent of the long period average (LPA), which is considered below normal. The LPA rainfall for July, based on the 1971 to 2020 period, is 280.4 mm.

“During July, below-normal rainfall is likely across most parts of the country except some areas of northwest and northeast India, east-central India and the eastern peninsular region, where normal to above-normal rainfall is likely,” Mohapatra said.

The IMD attributed the weak June monsoon to five major factors. These included an unfavourable phase of the Madden-Julian Oscillation (MJO), the absence of low-pressure systems during June, typhoon systems recurving towards the north-northwest instead of supporting rainfall over the Indian Ocean region, the emergence of El Nino conditions, and neutral Indian Ocean Dipole (IOD) conditions, which were unable to offset El Nino’s impact.

Meteorologists expect fresh low-pressure systems to develop over the Bay of Bengal and the monsoon trough to shift southward during the first week of July. These developments are expected to improve rainfall activity across central, western and northern India and could help reduce the rainfall deficit created by one of the driest Junes on record.

The IMD also said maximum temperatures are likely to remain above normal across most parts of the country during July, except a few isolated areas of west-central India. Minimum temperatures are also expected to stay above normal over most regions, with only some pockets of central and northeast India likely to record near-normal night temperatures.



EDITORIAL
UNCERTAIN
WATERS

The latest confrontation between Iran and the United States has once again exposed just how fragile the global energy system remains. The brief optimism that followed the interim US-Iran understanding has quickly dissipated after Iranian drone attacks on commercial shipping and retaliatory American strikes reignited military tensions in and around the Gulf. While the strait has not been formally closed, uncertainty has become the new blockade. Commercial shipping thrives on predictability, not merely physical access. Even when vessels continue to move, elevated insurance premiums, altered navigation routes, security escorts and the ever-present fear of attack impose enormous economic costs. Nearly one-fifth of the world's oil and liquefied natural gas exports pass through this narrow waterway. Any disruption, even if temporary, reverberates through global energy markets, freight costs and inflation expectations. The latest episode is therefore not simply another chapter in the US-Iran rivalry. It is a reminder that the global economy remains dangerously dependent on a single maritime chokepoint whose stability rests more on political calculations than on international guarantees.

The current impasse also reveals a deeper problem: competing interpretations of the same diplomatic agreement. Washington insists that the interim arrangement envisaged an open Strait of Hormuz free from Iranian interference during a 60-day negotiating window. Tehran, meanwhile, argues that the agreement merely commits it to facilitating safe passage while allowing Iran to determine the manner in which maritime traffic is managed. This divergence has transformed diplomacy into ambiguity. Iran's insistence that vessels follow routes close to its coastline, undergo vetting by agencies linked to the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps and, in some instances, comply with financial demands places international shipping companies in an impossible position. Compliance risks attracting Western sanctions because the IRGC is designated as a terrorist organisation by the United States and the European Union, while non-compliance invites operational risks from Iranian forces. Such conditions undermine the universally accepted principle of freedom of navigation enshrined in international maritime law. The United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea clearly protects the right of peaceful transit through international straits. If unilateral assertions of control become normalised in Hormuz, other critical maritime corridors—from the Strait of Malacca to the Bab el-Mandeb—could become vulnerable to similar geopolitical coercion. That would represent a dangerous erosion of the rules-based maritime order that has underpinned global trade for decades.

Yet the restrained reaction of oil markets also deserves attention. Contrary to expectations, crude prices have not returned to the dramatic highs witnessed during earlier Gulf crises. Brent crude remains broadly near pre-conflict levels, reflecting a market that has become more resilient than in previous decades. Several structural factors explain this composure. Strategic petroleum reserves released by major consuming nations have softened immediate supply concerns. Gulf producers, particularly Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates, have increasingly invested in pipeline infrastructure that bypasses Hormuz wherever possible. The United States has emerged as a far more significant energy exporter than it was during earlier regional crises, while weaker Chinese demand and slower global economic growth have moderated consumption. Even so, resilience should not be mistaken for immunity. Maritime insurers remain cautious, humanitarian evacuation operations remain suspended, and shipping companies continue to divert traffic between Iranian-controlled routes, the US-backed Omani corridor and less transparent “dark” voyages where tracking systems are deliberately switched off. Such behaviour reflects persistent uncertainty rather than restored confidence. Every additional day of ambiguity raises operational costs that eventually find their way into consumer prices, industrial production and global trade flows. The economic consequences of insecurity often emerge gradually rather than through sudden price spikes.

Ultimately, the Strait of Hormuz is becoming a test not merely of military deterrence but of diplomatic credibility and international governance. Neither Washington nor Tehran can afford an indefinite escalation, yet neither appears willing to concede political leverage before negotiations resume. President Donald Trump's assertion that further talks are imminent has not been matched by confirmation from Tehran, illustrating the trust deficit that continues to plague this relationship. For countries like India, Japan, South Korea and much of Europe, whose energy security depends heavily on uninterrupted Gulf supplies, prolonged uncertainty is deeply unsettling. The crisis also reinforces the urgent need to diversify energy sources, expand strategic reserves, strengthen alternative transport corridors and accelerate the transition towards cleaner fuels that reduce dependence on vulnerable chokepoints. However, such structural changes require years, while geopolitical crises unfold in days. Until then, safeguarding freedom of navigation must remain a collective international responsibility rather than the subject of unilateral interpretation or military brinkmanship. The Strait of Hormuz cannot become a bargaining chip in regional power politics. Its uninterrupted functioning is not merely an Iranian or American concern; it is a prerequisite for global economic stability. Diplomacy must therefore move beyond temporary ceasefires and ambiguous memoranda towards a durable framework that guarantees secure maritime passage, respects international law and prevents one of the world's most vital arteries from becoming a recurring flashpoint.

ILLNESS TO
WELLNESS



ANIL RAJPUT

THE WRITER IS THE
CHAIRPERSON,
ADVISORY
COUNCIL, ILLNESS
TO WELLNESS
FOUNDATION

National Doctors' Day 2026 should not be reduced to a ceremonial thank-you. It should be a day to recognise that doctors stand at the centre of India's next health transition

Every day, across India, doctors perform acts of service that rarely make headlines but quietly shape the health of the nation. A paediatrician helps anxious new parents understand how to nourish and protect a newborn. A physician guides a patient with diabetes towards better control and fewer complications. A doctor caring for an elderly patient helps preserve mobility, dignity and independence for a little longer. These are not always dramatic moments, yet they are among the most meaningful victories in healthcare. They remind us that the work of a doctor is not confined to treating disease. It is also about building confidence, preserving quality of life and helping people live more fully at every stage of life.

Every year on 1 July, India observes National Doctors' Day in honour of Dr Bidhan Chandra Roy, one of the country's most respected physicians and a Bharat Ratna awardee whose life symbolised service, scholarship and public duty. The day marks both his birth and death anniversary, and is traditionally used to thank doctors for their dedication to healing. Gratitude is important. But if National Doctors' Day 2026 is to truly reflect the needs of our time, it must do more than celebrate sacrifice. It must ask a larger question: what does India need from its doctors today, and what do doctors need from India in return?

That question matters because the role of the doctor is changing. The doctor of 2026 is not only the person we visit when we are ill. Increasingly, the doctor is also a guide to prevention, a counsellor in chronic disease, a trusted interpreter of health misinformation, a user of digital health tools and a partner in helping citizens live healthier lives. This is where National Doctors' Day becomes deeply relevant to the vision of the Illness to Wellness Foundation. The future of healthcare cannot be built only around treatment after disease strikes. It must also be built around prevention, early detection, continuity of care and a culture of wellness. In many ways, this is not a new idea for India. Our civilisational wisdom has long held that the highest form of healthcare is to preserve health before illness arises. The principle that prevention is better than cure, and that health must be protected through disciplined living, balanced food and harmony between body and mind, has deep roots in our tradition. In that future, doctors are not only healers. They are health leaders.

This shift is especially important for India because our health challenges are no longer defined only by infections



Doctors prescribe hope by simplifying complexity, calming fear, correcting misinformation and empowering patients with confidence and clarity

and emergencies. India continues to battle communicable diseases, maternal and child health challenges and unequal access to care. But alongside these, the country is also carrying a rising burden of hypertension, diabetes, obesity, cardiovascular disease, cancer, mental health concerns and the health consequences of sedentary lifestyles, poor diets, pollution and stress. These are not illnesses that can be solved by hospital care alone. They require screening, counselling, long-term follow-up, behavioural change and trust. They require doctors who can help patients not only recover from disease, but avoid preventable suffering in the first place.

Seen through the course of a lifetime, the doctor's role becomes even clearer. At the beginning of life, paediatricians help parents build a healthy foundation for a child through guidance on feeding, vaccination, sleep, growth and development. In adulthood, family physicians, internists and diabetologists do far more than prescribe medicines; they help patients understand the dos and don'ts of living with diabetes, hypertension and other chronic conditions before these become disabling. Later in life, physicians and geriatric specialists help older adults maintain function, mobility and dignity, so that added years are not merely longer years, but better years. In all these ways, doctors do something larger than treating illness. They protect health across the lifespan.

India's recent health innovations make this preventive and continuity-based role even more important. Telemedicine, stronger primary care, digital health records and AI-assisted clinical support all have the potential to help doctors reach patients earlier, follow them more consistently and reduce

the fragmentation that so often weakens care. Yet technology must remain a means, not an end. It should make healthcare more humane, more accessible and more continuous, not more mechanical or impersonal. A system that helps a doctor understand a patient's history, monitor chronic illness more effectively or reach a distant patient more easily is a system that can strengthen care. But technology must support the doctor, not replace the doctor. Algorithms can process data. They cannot replace clinical judgement, moral responsibility, empathy or the trust that allows a frightened patient to believe that healing is possible.

This is where the conversation must return to prevention in its deepest sense. Alongside the advances of modern medicine, India also carries a long tradition of health wisdom rooted in daily discipline, moderation and balance. Our understanding of Dincharya, or the ordering of daily life around healthy rhythms, reminds us that wellness is shaped not only in hospitals but in the ordinary habits of everyday living. The idea of food as nourishment, and in many cases as a form of preventive medicine, also runs through our traditional health knowledge. Combined with physical activity, mental balance, adequate rest and a holistic approach to living, such principles can help people remain healthier for longer, reduce avoidable disease and lower the economic burden of poor health on families and society. The real challenge before us is not only to add years to life, but life to those years. In a country facing both rising chronic illness and rising healthcare costs, these ideas deserve renewed attention.

But prevention cannot succeed without trust. In an age of internet

advice, social media remedies and conflicting health claims, the trust between doctor and patient becomes even more valuable. A doctor does not only prescribe medicine; a doctor interprets complexity, calms fear, corrects misinformation and gives patients the confidence to act with clarity rather than panic. Trust is not a sentimental quality in healthcare. It is a public-health asset that improves adherence, encourages early care-seeking and allows difficult health decisions to be made with confidence rather than confusion.

National Doctors' Day 2026, then, should not be reduced to a ceremonial thank-you. It should be a day to recognise that doctors stand at the centre of India's next health transition: not only in operating theatres and intensive care units, but also in prevention, early diagnosis, chronic disease management, digital care and healthy ageing. They are not only healers and health leaders. They are also nation builders. A Viksit Bharat cannot be built on an unhealthy foundation. No country can realise its economic, social and human potential if its people are chronically unwell, its families are financially broken by avoidable disease and its healthcare workers are exhausted by carrying too much for too long. No healthcare system can truly care for the patient if it does not also care for the caregiver. Supporting doctors, protecting their well-being and strengthening their ability to guide the nation towards better health is therefore not only a medical necessity; it is a national one.

For the Illness to Wellness Foundation, this is the heart of the message. A healthier India will not be built by hospitals alone. It will be built when prevention becomes a habit, screening becomes routine, trust in evidence becomes stronger and wellness becomes part of everyday life. It will also be built by recovering a deeper understanding of health: one that values balanced living, respects the role of food and daily discipline in prevention, and recognises that the quality of life matters as much as its duration. In this journey, the medical community can play a pivotal role. Doctors are often looked upon almost as demigods in moments of crisis; that moral authority also gives them the power to guide society towards healthier choices in a stressful and fast-paced world. On this National Doctors' Day, let us honour them not only for the diseases they treat, but for the confidence they restore, the trust they inspire and the healthier futures they help make possible.

Views expressed are personal

INDIA
RESPONDS



PRABHU DAYAL

THE WRITER IS A
RETIRED INDIAN
DIPLOMAT AND
HAD PREVIOUSLY
SERVED AS CONSUL
GENERAL IN
NEW YORK

Humanitarian assistance has become one of India's strongest instruments of global diplomacy

Compassion Across Continents

From strategic airlifts to portable field hospitals, India's response to Venezuela's devastating earthquakes reflects the country's expanding humanitarian footprint and its philosophy of 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam'

India's rapid deployment of Operation Amistad to deliver critical humanitarian aid and disaster relief to earthquake-stricken Venezuela exemplifies its emergence as a global first responder and its core civilisational philosophy of “Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam” (the world is one family). Following the catastrophic twin earthquakes (magnitudes 7.2 and 7.5) that struck northern Venezuela near Caracas on June 24, 2026, the resulting collapse of infrastructure left over 1,430 dead and thousands missing. India responded swiftly, demonstrating that its Humanitarian Assistance and Disaster Relief (HADR) capabilities transcend geographical limitations.

The deployment of such significant medical and physical resources to a Latin American nation reflects India's evolution from a regional relief provider to a proactive global partner. Following similar recent missions—such as Operation Brahma in Myanmar in 2025 and Operation Dost in Türkiye and Syria in 2023—India has continually demonstrated its institutional readiness to act as the “first responder” to calamities.

Operation Amistad
When twin shallow earthquakes measuring up to 7.5 on the moment magnitude scale struck northern Venezuela, they caused catastrophic destruction across coastal regions and the capital, Caracas. The disaster resulted in hundreds of casualties, thousands of injuries, and immense infrastructural damage. In direct response to appeals from the Venezuelan government, and following condolences offered by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India launched Operation Amistad (Amistad signifying “friendship” in Spanish). The operation represented one of India's longest transcontinental humanitarian airlifts.



Operation Amistad proves that India's humanitarian reach now extends far beyond its immediate neighbourhood

Strategic Delivery

Operation Amistad—derived from the Spanish word for “friendship”—is defined by its immense scale, speed, and sophisticated deployment framework.

Transoceanic Airlift: The Indian Air Force deployed two Boeing C-17 Globemaster strategic transport aircraft to fly a 14,000-kilometre transoceanic mission from India to Venezuela, transiting through Abidjan.

Massive Payload: The aircraft transported 66 tonnes of emergency materials, including 35 tonnes of general relief supplies (shelters, blankets, and survival gear), alongside 6 tonnes of critical medicines and emergency surgical kits.

Specialised Human Resources: A 41-member medical task force from the elite 60 Parachute Field Hospital (Agra)—comprising nine specialised medical officers—was dispatched to establish immediate emergency trauma infrastructure.

Cutting-Edge Medical Diplomacy

A hallmark of this operation is

India's deployment of advanced, home-grown medical technology. The shipment included a fully independent Indian Army Field Hospital Unit and two BHISHM Cubes (Bharat Health Initiative for Sahyog, Hita & Maitri). These state-of-the-art portable hospitals are designed for rapid assembly in active disaster zones. Each cube can independently treat up to 300 patients, providing operating theatres, intensive care, trauma diagnostics, and portable oxygen generation systems directly to regions where local facilities have been completely devastated.

Diplomatic Implications

While rooted firmly in humanitarian principles, Operation Amistad carries strong diplomatic resonance. India's ties with Venezuela have strengthened significantly in 2026, driven by a mutual push for energy diversification and humanitarian solidarity. Amid disruptions in West Asia and the easing of international restrictions, Venezuela rapidly emerged as India's third-largest crude oil supplier by May

2026, with Indian imports surging to 427,000 barrels per day. This renewed energy partnership was solidified during high-level bilateral talks in New Delhi between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Venezuelan Acting President Delcy Rodríguez, opening avenues for expanded Indian investments in Venezuela's upstream oil fields and deeper collaboration in pharmaceuticals, critical minerals, and digital public infrastructure.

The deepening bond between the two nations was further underscored by India's swift deployment of Operation Amistad, a major humanitarian assistance and disaster relief mission that delivered portable field hospitals and critical medical aid to Venezuela following the devastating earthquakes. India demonstrated that it stands “shoulder to shoulder” with the people of Venezuela, using proactive soft power to reinforce geopolitical goodwill across Latin America.

Conclusion

Ultimately, India's execution of Operation Amistad illustrates its transformation from a nation that once primarily received international aid into a reliable, technologically advanced global first responder. By delivering life-saving medical care and massive logistical support across hemispheres within days of a catastrophe, India has demonstrated that its armed forces and humanitarian instincts are powerful tools for global stability, blending operational excellence with universal compassion. India's swift dispatch of critical aid to earthquake-stricken Venezuela under Operation Amistad exemplifies the proverb, “A friend in need is a friend indeed.” Through this rapid, boots-on-the-ground support, India cemented its role as a reliable global partner, proving that compassion and assistance know no geographic boundaries.

Views expressed are personal

ARUNACHAL TOLL RISES TO 4

Assam flood situation remains grim; one dies, more than 46K affected

MPOST BUREAU

GUWAHATI/ITANAGAR: The flood situation remained critical in parts of Assam and Arunachal Pradesh on Tuesday, with one person killed in Assam and four deaths reported in Arunachal Pradesh as heavy rain, flash floods and landslides continued to affect large areas of the Northeast.

In Assam, a woman died in floodwaters at Sissiborgaon in Dhemaji district, marking the first flood-related death in the state this year, according to the Assam State Disaster Management Authority (ASDMA).

The ASDMA said over 46,900 people in six districts — Dhemaji, Nalbari, Dibrugarh, Chirang, Lakhimpur and Biswanath — were affected by the floods. Dhemaji remained the worst-hit district with more than 45,800 people impacted.

The number of affected people increased from around 45,500 on Monday as floodwaters continued to inundate villages and agricultural land. Altogether, 221 villages across 10 revenue circles remained under water.

The Brahmaputra was flowing above the danger level at Neamatighat, while the Disang river crossed the danger mark at Nanglamuraghat. More than 450 displaced people were staying in four relief camps, while six relief distribution centres were functioning in the affected areas. Over 3,800 hectares of cropland remained submerged, while more than 88,000 animals, including around 50,000 large ones, were affected. Roads and other infrastructure also suffered damage in many areas.

Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said the government was closely monitoring



Union ministers Shivraj Singh Chouhan and Kiren Rijiju along with Arunachal CM Pema Khandu inspect a flood-affected area

Scindia takes stock of flood situation

GUWAHATI: Union Minister Jyotiraditya M Scindia on Tuesday reviewed the flood situation across the northeastern region, following incessant rainfall.

He spoke with Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, Arunachal Pradesh CM Pema Khandu, Sikkim CM Prem Singh Tamang and Manipur Chief Minister Yumnam Khemchand Singh to assess the prevailing situation and review the ongoing rescue, relief and restoration efforts in the flood-affected areas.

During the telephonic interactions, Scindia, the Minister for Development of North Eastern Region (DoNER), took stock of the ground situation and assured the chief ministers of every possible support and assistance from his ministry to safeguard lives, strengthen relief operations and restore normalcy at the earliest.

the situation. Water Resources Minister Susanta Borgohain and Revenue and Disaster Management Minister Keshab Mahanta visited flood-hit areas in Gohpur and directed officials to take immediate protective measures.

Meanwhile, in neighbouring Arunachal Pradesh, four people have died, 21 were injured and two remained missing during the past week as heavy rain triggered flash floods and landslides across several districts.

Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan

and Union Minister Kiren Rijiju on Tuesday conducted aerial and ground assessments of the flood-ravaged Keyi Panyor district along with Chief Minister Pema Khandu. Khandu said the visit reflected the Centre's commitment to support the state during the crisis.

Chouhan said the two ministers had visited the state on the directions of PM Narendra Modi to assess the damage and ensure all possible assistance. Describing the devastation as severe, he said landslides and mudflows had damaged roads, bridges and houses.

Jantar Mantar: CJP protest enters day 11, concern grows over Wangchuk's health

Dipke dismisses social media claims that Wangchuk consuming food during fast

ANAMTA FATIMA/VIBHINTA KAUR

NEW DELHI: The protest led by the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) at Jantar Mantar entered its eleventh day on Tuesday, with concern mounting over the health of activist Sonam Wangchuk as his indefinite hunger strike entered third day.

According to a medical bulletin issued by the organisers, Wangchuk's blood pressure was recorded at 117/60, oxygen saturation at 96 per cent, pulse rate at 92 beats per minute and blood sugar level at 66, which is below the normal range. Doctors attending to him said the prevailing heat conditions had added to the physical stress of fasting and that his condition was being monitored closely.

The protest site also witnessed efforts to counter speculation surrounding Wangchuk's fast. Addressing reporters, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke dismissed social media claims



Activist Sonam Wangchuk during an indefinite hunger strike on Tuesday at the Jantar Mantar protest by the CJP

alleging that Wangchuk was consuming food during the hunger strike. He publicly displayed Wangchuk's water bottle and said misinformation should not divert attention from the issues being raised by the protesters.

The agitation received support from advocate Prashant Bhushan, who joined the protesters in solidarity with the indefinite fast. Speaking at the site, Bhushan criticised the government's handling of public

INSIGHT

» Doctors attending to him said the prevailing heat conditions had added to the physical stress of fasting and that his condition was being monitored closely

» The agitation received support from advocate Prashant Bhushan, who joined the protesters in solidarity with the indefinite fast

dissent and said the movement had attracted wider attention than initially expected.

Student participation continued to be a key feature of the protest.

Several student leaders associated with JNU, AISA and other university groups remained on hunger strike, saying repeated demonstrations and appeals had failed to elicit a meaningful response from the authorities. Student representatives said the movement

Pb CM launches statewide campaign on Guru Ravidass

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Tuesday flagged off 50 mobile documentary vans to spread the teachings and philosophy of Sri Guru Ravidass Ji Maharaj across the state as part of the celebrations marking his 650th Parkash Purab.

The specially designed vans, equipped with large LED screens, will travel across nearly 13,000 villages in all 23 districts of Punjab, screening a 30-minute documentary on the life, teachings and message of Sri Guru Ravidass Ji.

Mann said the initiative aims to take Guru Ji's message of equality, social justice, devotion and universal brotherhood to every household, especially the younger generation.

The Chief Minister said

Mann flagged off 50 documentary vans to spread the Guru's teachings

the state government has earmarked ₹100 crore for year-long programmes to commemorate the 650th Parkash Purab. He described the occasion as a matter of pride and said the government was committed to celebrating the event in a historic manner.

Highlighting the relevance of Guru Ravidass Ji's teachings, Mann said the saint preached equality, human dignity and an egalitarian society free from discrimination. He urged people to follow Guru Ji's ideals to build a harmonious society.

MPOST

Haryana cities to be developed to meet future needs: CM

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Tuesday said the state's cities would be developed in line with future requirements to ensure that citizens receive essential services efficiently and do not have to visit multiple offices to resolve their grievances.

Chairing a review meeting of the Urban Local Bodies Department's five-year roadmap and action plan under Haryana Vision-2047 at the Civil Secretariat, Saini reviewed the progress of government announcements and directed officials to expedite key urban development projects.

The Chief Minister said Haryana's cities would be taken to new heights of development over the next five years to contribute to the goal of Viksit Bharat 2047. He announced that 24x7 drinking water supply would be introduced on a pilot basis in Gurugram and Faridabad. Multilingual touch-screen kiosks and free Wi-Fi facilities will also be provided in urban areas.

Saini said an integrated super app is being developed to enable residents to pay property tax and water bills, register complaints and access various government services through their mobile phones. The app will also provide special services for senior citizens.

Emphasising water conservation, he directed that rainwater harvesting systems be made mandatory in government buildings and residential plots exceeding 250 square yards in urban areas. Officials informed that 120 such systems have already been installed in Gurugram, while 300 more are planned across 50 urban local bodies.

The Chief Minister also directed the plantation of one lakh saplings during the monsoon under the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign, with 20,000 saplings to be planted in Gurugram.

MPOST

Union minister Chouhan, CM Saini launch Haryana FPO Mission-2026

CHANDIGARH: Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Tuesday said sustainable farming, balanced use of fertilisers and adoption of modern agricultural practices are essential for building a developed India, as he addressed the concluding ceremony of the nationwide 'Khet Bachao Abhiyan' in Haryana's Rewari district.

The event, organised at the College of Agriculture in Bawal, was presided over by Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini. Haryana Agriculture Minister Shyam Singh Rana, ICAR Director General M.L. Jat and agricultural scientists also attended the programme.

Chouhan and Saini jointly inaugurated an agri-

cultural industrial exhibition and launched the Haryana FPO Mission-2026 aimed at strengthening Farmer Producer Organisations and promoting collective agricultural entrepreneurship.

Addressing farmers, Chouhan said India cannot become a developed nation without prosperous farmers and advanced agriculture. He said the Centre was committed to making farming more profitable, modern and sustainable through scientific methods and new technologies.

He praised Haryana as a model of agricultural development, noting that the state provides minimum support price on 24 crops and has implemented initiatives such as Bhavantar Bharpai Yojana, Meri

Fasal-Mera Byora and Mera Pani-Meri Virasat.

The Union minister cautioned against excessive use of chemical fertilisers such as urea and DAP, saying indiscriminate use harms soil fertility and the environment. He urged farmers to adopt soil testing, balanced fertiliser use and natural farming practices.

Chief Minister Saini said Haryana, despite accounting for only 1.3 per cent of the country's geographical area, is the second-largest contributor to the central foodgrain pool. He said the newly launched Haryana FPO Mission-2026 would strengthen nearly 775 existing farmer producer organisations and improve marketing, processing and value addition facilities.

MPOST

HIGHWAY MEETS HABITAT

Rajasthan: India's first 8-lane tunnel under tiger reserve to open in August

KOTA: Marking a significant milestone in balancing infrastructure development with wildlife conservation, India's first eight-lane highway tunnel on the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway, constructed beneath a tiger reserve in Rajasthan's Kota district, is set to officially open for all categories of vehicles in August this year.

Safety trials with light vehicles are currently underway.

The 4.9-km twin-tube tunnel, located beneath the Mukundra Hills Tiger Reserve (MHTR) in Rajasthan, has been opened initially for cars and emergency vehicles following the completion of safety inspections.

Heavy vehicles and all other traffic will be permitted only after additional evaluations regarding safety systems and mobile network connectivity inside the tunnel are completed by the authorities.

Project Director Sandeep Agrawal from the National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) in Kota stated: "The

KEY POINTS

- » Safety trials with light vehicles are currently underway
- » The 4.9-km twin-tube tunnel, located beneath the Mukundra Hills Tiger Reserve (MHTR) in Rajasthan, has been opened initially for cars and emergency vehicles following the completion of safety inspections

eight-lane highway tunnel on the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway beneath MHTR has not yet been officially opened for all vehicle categories. Currently, only trials are underway with light vehicles such as cars."

While the civil work on the tunnel is nearly complete, other ongoing work inside the tunnel is being conducted alongside regular testing, he added.

Agrawal noted that the tunnel is expected to officially open for all vehicle categories in August, following directives



» Heavy vehicles and all other traffic will be permitted only after additional evaluations regarding safety systems and mobile network connectivity

from the Union Ministry.

According to NHAI officials, the tunnel has been constructed entirely beneath the tiger reserve to avoid disturbing wildlife movement and to preserve the forest ecosystem.

Its design allows animals to move freely above the tunnel without interference from highway traffic, making it an exemplary case of integrating transport infrastructure with environmental conservation.

The tunnel features twin tubes, each carrying four traf-

fic lanes, making it India's first eight-lane tunnel beneath a wildlife sanctuary. Specialised engineering techniques were used in the development to minimise ecological impact while ensuring safe and efficient traffic flow.

The project took over four years to complete, with engineers overcoming geological and environmental challenges while adhering to stringent conservation standards.

Wildlife corridors in the reserve have been maintained to ensure the uninterrupted movement of tigers and other animals.

The tunnel is expected to substantially reduce travel time on the Delhi-Vadodara stretch of the Delhi-Mumbai Expressway by eliminating nearly 25 km of winding road through the reserve.

Officials anticipate that once the entire expressway is fully operational, the overall travel time between Delhi and Vadodara could be reduced from approximately 20-22 hours to about 10-12 hours.

AGENCIES

Rlys approves doubling of Mansi-Saharsa line

NEW DELHI: In a major boost to railway infrastructure in Bihar, Indian Railways has approved the doubling of the 44.40-km Mansi-Saharsa section of East Central Railway at an estimated cost of Rs 499 crore.

The Mansi-Saharsa stretch, part of the Mansi-Saraighar route, currently operates as a single-line corridor and handles heavy passenger and freight traffic. Around 24 pairs of passenger trains run on the section daily, besides freight movement of commodities such as wheat, maize, cement, fertilisers, rice, salt, sand, stone and sugar. Officials said the line capacity utilisation has already reached 108.11 per cent and is expected to rise to 119.34 per cent by 2028-29, highlighting need for additional capacity.

The doubling project is expected to ease congestion, improve punctuality and enhance operational efficiency. Once completed, it will facilitate the movement of an additional 1.764 million tonnes of freight annually.

MPOST

Nation Briefs

NFR IMPLEMENTS SMART ONLINE LIFT MONITORING SYSTEM AT MAJOR STATIONS

MALIGAON: Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) has introduced the Indian Railways Native IoT-based Yield Analysis, Telemetry, Recording and Control (IR-NIYANTRAC)



system for online monitoring of lifts at key stations under Rangiya Division. Developed by the Centre for Railway Information Systems (CRIS), the system enables real-time monitoring of lift operations, detects faults instantly and sends alerts to maintenance staff, ensuring quicker repairs and reduced downtime. The project has been fully implemented, covering four lifts at two stations — New Bongaigaon and Rangiya.

ECR: RAILWAYS EXTENDS OPERATIONS OF FIVE SPECIAL TRAINS

HAJIPUR: In view of heavy passenger demand, the Railways has extended the operation of several special trains. The Raxaul-Lokmanya Tilak special (05557/05558) will continue till the end of July, while the Patna-Cherlapalli (03253/03254/03255) and Patna-Khurda Road (03230/03229) special trains have also been extended till July-end, the East Central Railway said on Tuesday. The Patna-Howrah special (02024/02023) will now operate every Sunday until September 27. Meanwhile, the Sagaria-Dhanbad special (09821/09822) will run between July 16 and November 28.

Monsoon arrives in most parts of U'khand

DEHRADUN: The South-west Monsoon arrived in most parts of Uttarakhand on Tuesday, bringing heavy rainfall and providing relief from heat and humidity.

Announcing the monsoon's arrival across the majority of the state, the Dehradun Meteorological Centre stated that conditions are favourable for it to reach the remaining areas within the next two to three days. According to the centre, Dehradun recorded 57.8 mm of rainfall on Tuesday, while Champawat recorded 60 mm, Kalsi 49 mm, and Chakrata 14 mm. An 'orange alert' has been issued for Dehradun and Bageshwar districts, predicting isolated heavy to very heavy rainfall on Wednesday.

A 'yellow alert' has been issued for Tehri, Pauri, Nainital, Champawat, Udham Singh Nagar, Pithoragarh and Haridwar.

MPOST

RESCUE OPS UNDERWAY

Haryana: 4-yr-old child falls into 220-foot deep borewell in Ambala

AMBALA: A four-year-old boy fell into a 220-foot-deep open borewell in Haryana's Ambala district on Tuesday, triggering a massive rescue operation involving the NDRE, SDRF and Army personnel.

The incident occurred around 6.30 am in Dhaneora village when Nirvair Singh had accompanied his father, Manjit Singh, to the fields to deliver food to his grandfather. While playing near the field, the child reportedly slipped into the approximately nine-inch-wide borewell.

Deputy Commissioner Ajay Singh Tomar and other officials rushed to the spot after receiving information. Rescue teams



lowered a camera into the borewell to monitor the child and assess his condition.

Officials said attempts were being made to pull the child out using ropes and specialised equipment. The operation continued for nearly 10 hours, with the Army joining the rescue efforts.

Tomar said water seepage inside the borewell was cre-

ating visibility problems and hampering rescue operations. He said the administration was making every effort to ensure the child's safe rescue.

According to officials, the boy had been playing near the borewell and was throwing soil into it when the wet ground around the opening gave way, causing him to fall.

Family members and villagers initially tried to rescue the child before informing authorities. Tents were erected at the site due to rain, while police have been directed to take action against those responsible for leaving the borewell uncovered.

MPOST

GEN UPENDRA DWIVEDI SIGNS OFF

Gen Dhiraj Seth takes charge as Army Chief

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: General Dhiraj Seth on Tuesday took charge as the 31st Chief of the Army Staff, succeeding General Upendra Dwivedi, who retired after more than four decades of distinguished service in the Indian Army.

Gen Seth assumed command of the 1.3 million-strong force at a time when the Army is pursuing its transformation into a self-reliant and future-ready force while dealing with evolving security challenges along the country's borders and adapting to the changing nature of warfare.

An alumnus of the National Defence Academy, Khadakwasla, Gen Seth was commissioned into the Armoured



Outgoing Chief of the Army Staff General Upendra Dwivedi accorded a Guard of Honour during his ceremonial farewell, in New Delhi

Corps in December 1986. Before taking over as Army chief, he served as the Vice Chief of the Army Staff.

The general officer brings with him nearly four decades of experience across operational, strategic, capability development and institutional domains. On his elevation to the rank of Army Com-

mander, he headed both the Jaipur-based South Western Command and the Pune-based Southern Command, earning the rare distinction of leading two operational commands along the western front.

He also held key appointments related to strategic planning and capability development at Army Headquarters.

Before becoming Vice Chief on April 1, Gen Seth led the Southern Command, which maintained a high level of operational readiness during Operation Sindoor.

His appointment comes at a time when the global security environment is becoming increasingly complex, with rapid technological changes and evolving military doctrines reshaping modern warfare.

Earlier in the day, outgoing Army chief Gen Dwivedi was accorded a ceremonial guard of honour on the lawns of South Block as he bid farewell to the force after serving for more than 40 years. Before the ceremony, he visited the National War Memorial and laid a wreath to pay tribute to the country's fallen soldiers.

GRAM PANCHAYATS WILL CONTINUE TO PLAY KEY ROLE IN IMPLEMENTATION OF SCHEME

VB-G RAM G Act to come into force from today, govt all ready for rollout

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Viksit Bharat -- Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025 will come into force from July 1, with the Centre on Tuesday stating that all arrangements have been made for its implementation.

The Ministry of Rural Development said the Act provides a statutory guarantee of up to 125 days of wage employment to eligible rural households, compared to the 100 days provided under the existing rural employment framework.

The ministry said an interim allocation of Rs 95,692.31 crore has been made to states and Union Territories to ensure a smooth transition, timely wage payments and uninterrupted implementation of works under the new framework.

Union Rural Development minister Shivraj Singh Chou-

Highlights

» 'Act provides a statutory guarantee of up to 125 days of wage employment to eligible rural households'

» The ministry said an interim allocation of Rs 95,692.31 crore has been made to states and Union Territories

» The government



said existing e-KYC-verified job cards will remain valid until the

new Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Cards are issued

han said the government's priority was to ensure that "no eligible rural worker remains without work even for a single day". He said the Centre and states had worked together to complete administrative, financial and technical preparations for the rollout.

The government said existing e-KYC-verified job cards

will remain valid until the new Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Cards are issued.

The Gram Panchayats will continue to play a key role in implementation of the scheme, with focus on areas such as natural resource management, water conservation, agriculture and allied activities, rural infrastructure and women's empow-

erment, it added.

According to the ministry, 29 states and Union Territories have made budgetary provisions for the Act, while 24 states have notified their VB-G RAM G state schemes.

The rollout of the new law comes amid criticism from Opposition parties and rural employment activists, who

have raised concerns over changes in the existing rural employment guarantee framework. They have questioned if the new system could affect the demand-driven nature of employment, the role of states and panchayats, and whether adequate financial resources would be available for implementation.

The government has maintained that the new framework will strengthen rural livelihood security, improve asset creation and provide a more comprehensive approach to employment generation.

The national launch of the VB-G RAM G Act will be held on July 2 at Mukkavaripalli village in Obulavaripalle mandal of Andhra Pradesh's Tirupati district, according to the ministry.

The event will include the distribution of Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Cards and the release of awareness material related to the mission.

Cong delegation prevented from visiting Ram temple in Ayodhya

Uttar Pradesh party chief Ajay Rai alleges 'house arrest'

OUR CORRESPONDENT



Police personnel stand guard outside the hotel after Congress delegation were placed under house arrest, in Ayodhya, Tuesday

Deepak Singh and around half a dozen other local party leaders were at a hotel since Monday night. The police reached there and did not allow them to leave for the Ram temple. On Tuesday evening, Sharma left for Delhi from the Ayodhya airport, an associate of the MP told news agency.

"The police and the administration forcibly brought me to the airport. They did not allow me to pay obeisance. If they stop me today, I will come tomorrow," Sharma told reporters.

Around two dozen Congress workers, including youth wing leader Sharad Shukla, were detained and taken to police lines when they were holding a sit-in outside the Acharya Narendra Dev University in Kumar Ganj, where Rai remained in a guest house under police watch. They were demanding that the party leaders be allowed to visit the Ram temple, according to police sources.

AYODHYA: Uttar Pradesh Congress chief Ajay Rai and other members of a party delegation were on Tuesday prevented from visiting the Ram temple in Ayodhya, where the alleged theft of donations has sparked a major political storm and put the ruling BJP on the backfoot.

Rai claimed he has been placed under "house arrest" here and said he would not leave Ayodhya until he is allowed to offer prayers at the Ram temple.

According to the Congress leader, members of the party delegation travelling separately for Tuesday's visit were either stopped on the way, confined to their homes or detained by police. However, there was no official word on the action against them.

The Congress team led by Rai was scheduled to visit Ayodhya on Tuesday amid the ongoing controversy over

the alleged embezzlement of donations at the shrine. Its members included MPs Kishori Lal Sharma (Amethi), Rakesh Rathor (Sitapur), Ujjwal Raman Singh (Prayagraj) and Tanuj Punia (Barabanki).

"They could not stop the donation theft, but they have stopped us Hindus from offering prayers at the temple. What kind of sanatana tradition is this that prevents people from having darshan?" Amethi MP Sharma said.

Sharma, former MLC

MARTYRS ROW

Venugopal seeks privilege proceedings against Rajnath for 'misleading' Parl

NEW DELHI: Congress leader K C Venugopal on Tuesday wrote to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla demanding that privilege proceedings be initiated against Defence minister Rajnath Singh for "misleading" Parliament by saying that no Indian soldier was martyred post the Pahal-gam terror attack last year.

In his letter to the speaker, Venugopal gave a notice of privilege under Rule 223 of the Rules of Procedure and Conduct of Business in Lok Sabha against the defence minister for having "misled" the House.

Venugopal said that on July 28, 2025, during discussions on the terrorist attack in Pahal-gam and the Operation Sindoor that



Rajnath Singh

followed, Rajnath Singh said that no harm was caused to the Indian soldiers.

Later, Venugopal said, a statement was issued that said six armed forces personnel had died during Operation Sindoor.

"The aforesaid position clearly indicates that the minister of defence stating on the floor of the House that there had been no casualties during

Operation Sindoor was clearly misleading and incorrect.

"It is well established that misleading the House or withholding information by a minister on the floor of the House constitutes a breach of privilege and contempt of Parliament.

"In view of the foregoing, I request that privilege proceedings be initiated against the minister of defence in the matter," Venugopal, who is the chairman of the Public Accounts Committee of Parliament, said.

In a post on X, Venugopal claimed that during the debate on Operation Sindoor in Lok Sabha, Singh lied to the people of India.

TO ENHANCE DIGITAL GOVERNANCE AND CITIZEN SERVICES

Shah launches revamped FCRA portal, e-OCI card

NARESH BISWANI



NEW DELHI: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Friday launched the FCRA 2.0 Portal and the Electronic Overseas Citizen of India (e-OCI) Card, two major digital initiatives aimed at simplifying public services, improving transparency and strengthening national security through technology-driven governance.

Security checks are embedded within the system architecture itself, reducing manual oversight needs. While efficiency gains appear evident, equal emphasis rests on safeguarding data integrity throughout transactions. Oversight mechanisms adapt in real time, responding to

inputs without delays typical of legacy frameworks.

These digital platforms aim to simplify processes for people and institutions alike, aligning with Prime Minister Narendra Modi's principle of minimal bureaucracy and effi-

cient administration. Underlined by openness in policy, defined objectives, and technological integration, governance becomes smoother for compliant individuals.

Oversight remains firm, however, for anyone breaking

legal norms. The launch reflects a shift toward structured accessibility without compromising control mechanisms.

Modern tools shape the new FCRA 2.0 system, shifting core processes online. Instead of paper, registration now flows through a secure portal. Renewal requests appear digitally, avoiding delays tied to physical forms. Annual reporting follows similar paths, reducing human handling.

Other submissions also enter via this central hub. Efficiency gains emerge from such uniform access points. Nearly 14,500 groups currently hold valid status across the country. Application volume ranges between 15,000 and 20,000 each year.

UP: SP chief whip Kamal Akhtar resigns

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party MLA from Kanth in Moradabad, Kamal Akhtar, on Monday resigned as the party's chief whip in the Uttar Pradesh Assembly, reigniting speculation over his growing differences with Moradabad MP Ruchi Veera.

I have always followed whatever directions I got from the national president, Akhilesh Yadav ji. Whatever direction he will give will be followed," Akhtar told reporters.

He said organisational changes were a continuous process in every political party and that no post was permanent.

"Just as the term of the legislature comes to an end and people are replaced by new faces, the same process applies to organisational positions," he said

The party has not issued any official statement on the reasons behind Akhtar's resignation.

However, the development comes days after a public fallout between the Ruchi Veera and him, prompting party president Akhilesh Yadav to intervene.

Taking to social media, Akhtar said he had always followed the directions of party chief Akhilesh Yadav and would continue to abide by every order issued by him in the future.

"I have always followed the instructions of national president Akhilesh Yadav and will continue to do so," he wrote.

CM Sukhu travels Bara Bhangal, remotest mountain area, stays overnight

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: From the high-altitude snow deserts of Spiti to the rugged valleys of Pangri, and from the remote hamlets of Dodra Kwar to the inaccessible expanse of Bara Bhangal, Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu has increasingly chosen some of Himachal Pradesh's farthest frontiers to take governance directly to the people.

In a conscious departure from conventional administrative outreach, Sukhu last week embarked upon a new journey to one of the state's highly underdeveloped regions in the Bajinath sub-division of Kangra, the state's largest district.

Bara Bhangal has no road connectivity, and the area remains cut off from the world for at least six months to a year. Situated in the Pir Panjal and Dhauladhar ranges, it is famously known as the only revenue village in India without a postal address. Yet, Sukhu left and made an attempt to make the people realise the power of the government, which can take care of their problems, and explore possibilities of necessities and road connectivity in their land.

Walking through a region where residents live only with basic means of livelihood and limited access to essential services, Sukhu interacted closely with villagers, listened to their concerns, and sought to bridge the distance between the state's corridors of power and its remotest citizens.

"CM Sukhu's resolve to travel to the area stands as a strong testament to his commitment towards the holistic development of people living in far-flung areas. It is evident that the govt's development agenda is not confined to roads and urban centres but is driven by the resolve to reach every citizen living in the remotest corners," said Naresh Chauhan, Principal Media Advisor to the Chief Minister.

Congress questions presence of serving officers on Aravalli panel

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Tuesday said the threat to the Aravalli hills due to "redefinition" remains as he questioned how unbiased the high-powered committee examining the issue would be as it includes several serving officials.

"Now the Supreme Court has set up a five-member High-Powered Committee to examine the issue of redefinition afresh and in detail. The Committee is packed with officials or retired officials.

"The fact that it will be chaired by a serving officer of the Union Ministry of Environment, Forests & Climate

'Clearly, the redefinition threat to the Aravalli ecosystem is still there'

Change and will have as its Member Secretary another serving officer of the Union Ministry of Environment, Forests, & Climate Change is very disappointing and raises serious questions on how independent and unbiased the Committee can and will be," he said in a post on X.

Ramesh, however, said this is no reflection on the distinguished members themselves, "but it is the reality given the Modi regime's mindset, toolkit,

and operating system".

"Clearly, the redefinition threat to the Aravalli ecosystem is still there. There had been enormous public, media, and civil society pressure when the first verdict had been delivered on November 20, 2025," the former environment minister said.

That pressure now needs to be sustained and intensified, he said. "We can only hope that the Committee will not end up backing the November 20, 2025, judgment in any form or to any degree. Simply put, there is no justifiable case whatsoever for a redefinition. The Forest Survey of India had itself rejected it in September 2025," the Congress leader said.

Haryana, Assam, Goa and Punjab lead states in rollout of new criminal laws

As many as 23 states, UTs have fully integrated into the new version of ICJS 2.0

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Haryana, Goa, Assam, Chandigarh and Punjab have emerged as the five best-performing states and Union territories in the country in implementing the three new criminal laws that came into force two years ago, officials said.

The performance of each state is adjudged on the basis of scores across four parameters--administrative reforms, operational efficiency, information and communication technology (ICT) application, and integration, they said.

The weightage of these parameters varies with regular revisions and changes being made, the officials said.

The three new criminal laws-- Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023; Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023; and Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, 2023-- which replaced the British-era criminal laws, were implemented on July 1, 2024, marking a watershed moment in the country's criminal jurisprudence.

The new laws aim to com-

Key Points

» 'The performance of each state is adjudged on the basis of scores across four parameters-- administrative reforms, operational efficiency, information and communication technology (ICT) application, and integration'

» The three new criminal laws-- Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023; Bharatiya

Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023; and Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, 2023-- which replaced the British-era criminal laws, were implemented on July 1, 2024, marking a watershed moment in the country's criminal jurisprudence

» The new laws aim to complete the process from FIR to a Supreme Court decision within three years, officials said

As many as 23 states and UTs have fully integrated into the new version of ICJS 2.0.

Haryana, Goa, Assam, Chandigarh, and Punjab have emerged as the best performers in these categories, the officials said, asserting that most states are above the national average.

States like West Bengal and Tamil Nadu also reported progress in implementing the provisions of the new laws, they said.

The officials cited one of the oldest jails in the country--the Presidency prison using video conferencing facilities as mandated under the new criminal laws.

According to the data provided by the Union Home Ministry, 39.56 per cent of chargesheets were filed within the 90-day mandatory deadline under the new criminal laws in 2024, which has spiralled to 60.96 per cent in 2026.

Similarly, the share of chargesheets with mandatory 60-day deadlines rose from 50.92 per cent in 2024 to 67.26 per cent in 2026.

According to the data, 44 per cent of chargesheets in sexual offence cases were filed within the mandatory two-month period, which has risen to 75.16 per cent in 2025. During the last two years, 74.66 lakh FIRs have been registered under the BNS, while 63,572 zero FIRs have also been registered.

Police across the country generated 46.50 lakh evidence IDs using the e-Sakshya application.

TN CM presents awards to collectors, police officials

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay presented meritorious awards to district collectors and police officials at the conclusion of the two-day conference here on Tuesday.

The awards were given to the collectors, police and forest officials for their performance during the past year focusing on administrative, field-level excellence, welfare and public service.

The CM gave away the best collector award to Kanyakumari district collector R Alugumeena recognising her work in effectively resolving the petitions received under the CM grievance redressal cell.

Wrapping up the joint conference, the chief minister asked the district heads to focus on improving basic amenities for the people.

He reviewed the activities of the forest department, wildlife conflict and eco-sensitive monitoring, socio-economic programmes and discussion on long-term plans, an official source said.

Nation Briefs

HP: THREE BJP COUNCILLORS IN DHARAMSHALA FACING DISQUALIFICATION

DHARAMSHALA: Three newly elected BJP councillors in the Dharamshala Municipal Corporation in Himachal Pradesh are facing disqualification following allegations of encroachment on government land. The Kangra Deputy Commissioner has recommended action against them to the Himachal Pradesh Government, citing the findings of an inquiry. The development is significant as the BJP currently has 11 seats in the 17-member municipal corporation. If all three are disqualified, the party's strength will be reduced to eight, bringing it below the majority mark.

DOOR-TO-DOOR SIR EXERCISE STARTS IN KARNATAKA

BENGALURU: A door-to-door house enumeration exercise under the SIR of electoral rolls began on Tuesday in Karnataka, with more than 5.54 crore electors set to be covered till July 29. The state government has announced that Permanent Residence Certificates (PRCs) will be issued to those in need during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR). The enumeration drive started with Chief Minister D K Shivakumar who filled up his enumeration form at his residence, along with his wife Usha Shivakumar, in the presence of Bengaluru South Deputy Commissioner and other officials. He urged voters in the state to actively participate in the SIR, submit their enumeration forms before the July 29 deadline and update their mobile numbers to ensure their electoral records remain current.

Economy resilient, but monsoon, geopolitical risks persist: FinMin

Easing in global commodity markets, correction in oil prices, softening of key input prices may help moderate imported inflationary pressures

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The economy remains resilient, though moderation in some high-frequency indicators suggests a gradual easing of momentum, a Finance Ministry report said, while flagging risks from uneven monsoon rainfall, emerging El Nino conditions and geopolitical uncertainties.

Following the robust growth performance in 2025-26, economic activity remained resilient in the initial months of 2026-27, the finance ministry said in its latest Monthly Economic Review. "High-frequency indicators such as e-way bill generation, PMI indices, electricity consumption, and automobile sales continued to reflect underlying strength in domestic economic activity."

"At the same time, moderation in select indicators, including core industries, fuel consumption, air passenger traffic, consumer confidence, and labour market indicators, suggests some easing in momentum," it said. As the global environment continues to evolve, inflation readings may remain relatively contained in the coming months. Recent easing in global commodity markets, a correction in crude oil prices, and softening of key



Following the robust growth performance in FY26, economic activity remained resilient in the initial months of FY27, the finance ministry said in its latest Monthly Economic Review

input prices, such as urea, may help moderate imported inflationary pressures, it added.

Although the normalisation of global supply chains and trade flows to pre-conflict levels may take time, the ministry said the decline in international commodity prices is expected to provide some cushion against further price pressures.

Government interventions, adequate buffer stocks of key agricultural commodities, and continued supply-side man-

Highlights

» 'High-frequency indicators like e-way bill generation, PMI indices, electricity consumption, & auto sales continued to reflect underlying strength in domestic economic activity

» As the global environment continues to evolve, inflation readings may remain relatively contained in the coming months

» Falling int'l commodity prices likely to provide some cushion against further price pressures

agement measures also help mitigate potential supply disruptions, it pointed out.

Overall, developments during the month point to continued strength in industrial activity, supported by policy reforms and investment momentum, it said, adding that the revised IIP and WPI frameworks are expected to more efficiently measure industrial and price dynamics. The report said the external sector remains supported by strong

export performance, resilient FDI inflows, and comfortable foreign exchange reserves.

The recent de-escalation of tensions in West Asia and progress in US-Iran negotiations have contributed to a correction in Brent crude oil prices, providing some relief from external and inflationary pressures. Recent progress on trade agreements and measures is also expected to further facilitate foreign capital inflows, it said.

Overall, it said, "the economy continues to exhibit resilience. However, moderation in select high-frequency indicators suggests some easing in momentum. The uneven distribution of monsoon rainfall, emerging El Niño conditions, and geopolitical uncertainties will continue to shape the outlook". Although recent developments in West Asia have eased pressure on global energy markets, continued disruptions to oil production and shipping through the Strait of Hormuz could affect energy supplies and commodity prices, it added.

The cessation of the conflict in West Asia has brightened the outlook for growth and also reduced inflation and external deficit risks, it said, adding that India's resilient merchandise export growth is a bright spot, and free trade agreements

coming into effect should boost export growth further.

"The longer-than-expected duration of the conflict in West Asia tested India's resilience. Indian policymakers dealt with it with a combination of near-term and structural measures designed to enhance the country's resilience to future energy shocks and their economic impacts. India's macroeconomic stability held, and concerns over external stability should dissipate gradually," the report said. Foreign debt investors have returned to the Indian sovereign debt market, and it is a matter of time before equity flows turn positive as concerns over the global AI-bubble mount, it noted.

However, the report said, the West Asia conflict was a reminder of the need for a national policy on buffer stocks for a range of critical raw materials and inputs. "Now, attention turns to the impact of a deficient monsoon. While the monsoon rains are expected to improve in July and August, experts point to the increasing unpredictability of rainfall patterns. Among other things, water conservation, including recycling, utilisation of budgetary allocations for Jal Jeevan Mission, may now be at the top of the policy priority list," it said.

US-Iran interim peace deal to provide tailwinds for growth: RBI

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: The Reserve Bank on Tuesday said the interim peace deal between Iran and the US can provide tailwinds to Indian economic growth.

In its bi-annual financial stability report released on Tuesday, the central bank also said that the growth in gold imports has decelerated "substantially" in May 2026 over April.

It, however, flagged that fiscal deficit can come under pressure because of the higher prices of energy and other commodities, their limited pass through to pump prices, excise duty cuts and higher outgo on subsidies.

"... the interim peace deal has laid the foundation for cessation of this conflict and normalisation of supply chains, which could provide tailwinds to growth," the report said.

The country entered the recent bout of global turbulence triggered by the West Asia conflict with stronger macroeconomic fundamentals, it said, conceding that while India's resilience provides an important buffer, some impact is inevitable given the country's substantial dependence on imported energy.

The RBI said most of the high-frequency indicators for April-May 2026 point to continued resilience in economic activity which suggests that growth has remained "firm" in Q1FY27.

"Nevertheless, elevated oil and other commodity prices and weaker global growth



Gross NPAs of banks reduced to 1.8 per cent at the end of March, a multi-decadal low, the RBI's financial stability report said

could adversely affect India's domestic growth in 2026-27," it said.

Several measures undertaken by the Government, including support to MSME and export sectors, are expected to help sustain economic activity, while mitigating the impact of external shocks, the central bank said.

On the inflation front, it said a combination of conflict-driven supply shock and projected weak monsoon due to El Niño can push headline inflation to the higher end of the tolerance band or around 6 per cent in Q3FY27 and also worsen inflation expectations.

The recent decline in net FDI (foreign direct investment) may reflect the tightening of global financial conditions, it said, adding that foreign portfolio flows to India have also been under pressure.

Asserting that India's external sector remains "resilient", the FSR said, "The recent measures announced by the Government and the RBI are expected to bolster capital inflows. Therefore, even if the CAD widens, stronger capital inflows are likely to mitigate the funding constraint."

The report also stated that fiscal deficit could come under pressure on higher prices of energy and other commodities, limited pass-through of oil price increase, excise duty cuts, and higher outgo on account of subsidies.

Gross non-performing assets of banks reduced to 1.8 per cent at the end of March, a multi-decadal low, the report said, adding that banking system gross NPAs may inch up to 1.9 per cent by March 2028 under the baseline scenario.

Rupee falls 5 paise to 94.56 against dollar



MUMBAI: The rupee depreciated by 5 paise to close at 94.56 against the US dollar on Tuesday, as a strengthening greenback overseas and risk-averse investor sentiment weighed on the local unit.

Forex traders said the rupee slipped to 94.58 against the US dollar, driven by month-end corporate import demand and lingering risk-off sentiment. However, relatively stable global crude prices and anticipated central bank interventions supported the currency and restricted the slide.

In the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 94.60 against the American currency and finally closed at 94.56, down 5 paise from its previous close.

On Monday, the rupee pared initial gains and settled lower by 6 paise at 94.51 against the dollar.

"The Indian rupee depreciated for the third consecutive session, weighed down by persistent safe-haven flows into the greenback and strong corporate dollar demand. Broader risk-off sentiment across global markets continues to keep the domestic currency under pressure," Dilip Parmar, Research Analyst, HDFC Securities, said.

'Domestic financial system remains resilient despite external shocks'

MUMBAI: Domestic financial system remains resilient, underpinned by strong bank and non-bank balance sheets, said the RBI's Financial Stability Report released on Tuesday.

Scheduled Commercial Banks remain safe and sound, supported by strong capital and liquidity buffers, continued improvement in asset quality, and stable profitability, it said.

It further said macro stress test results indicate that the banking system remains well-positioned to absorb potential shocks, with aggregate capital ratios projected to remain comfortably above regulatory thresholds even under hypothetical adverse scenarios.

NBFCs also remain financially sound, supported by

strong capitalisation, healthy profitability, and improving asset quality. However, the report noted that AI-enabled cyberattacks are the most important near-term challenge from a cyber threats perspective.

In the Foreword to the report, RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra said that the global economy and the financial system are being reshaped by two profound forces — growing geopolitical fragmentation and technological disruption brought about by rapid advances in AI. Despite ongoing conflicts and persistent supply chain disruptions, the global economy has remained resilient, buoyed in part by optimism about potential AI-driven

productivity gains, he said, adding that the near-term outlook, however, remains uncertain amid the rapidly evolving global environment.

"The Indian economy and the financial system have demonstrated remarkable resilience despite facing external shocks of significant magnitude. Strong growth, low inflation, healthy balance sheets of financial and nonfinancial firms, and ample buffers have helped preserve macro-financial stability," Malhotra said. "Nevertheless, we remain alert to evolving external and domestic risks and are committed to further strengthening the guardrails that protect our economy and financial system from potential shocks," he said.

Markets decline for second straight day as IT shares lead losses, Sensex falls 250 points

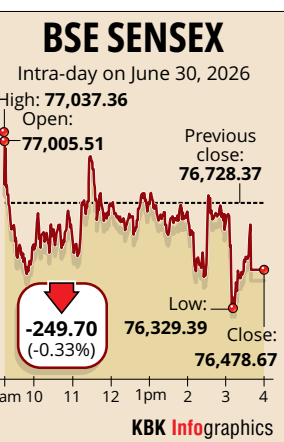
MUMBAI: Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty declined on Tuesday due to selling in IT, oil & gas and select banking shares amid uncertainty over the next round of US-Iran negotiations in Doha.

The 30-share BSE Sensex declined 249.70 points, or 0.33 per cent, to settle at 76,478.67, paring its opening gains.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 80.50 points, or 0.34 per cent, to end at 23,865.75.

Among Sensex shares, Infosys, Tata Consultancy Services, HCL Tech, Tech Mahindra, ITC and Hindustan Unilever were the major laggards.

Maruti, Titan, Bajaj Finance and Eternal were among the gainers.



Select index went up by 0.59 per cent MidCap Select index rose by 0.46 per cent.

Sectorally, BSE Focused IT tanked 2.62 per cent, followed by IT (2.48 per cent), PSU Bank (0.68 per cent), Bankex (0.25 per cent), Top 10 Banks (0.23 per cent), Metal (0.18 per cent), Utilities (0.12 per cent) and Private Banks index (0.12 per cent).

Realty jumped 1.23 per cent, while Services (1.01 per cent), Consumer Durables (0.98 per cent), Consumer Discretionary (0.81 per cent), MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt (0.59 per cent), Healthcare (0.58 per cent), Capital Goods (0.55 per cent) and Commodities (0.32 per cent) were among the gainers.

FICCI CASCADE seeks united action against smuggling and counterfeiting

HYDERABAD: Speakers at a FICCI CASCADE seminar on "Illicit Trade: A Unified Approach to Counter Smuggling and Counterfeiting" on Tuesday called for stronger coordination among governments, enforcement agencies, industry and consumers to curb illicit trade.

Dr. J. Ram Chander Naik, Deputy Speaker of the Telangana Assembly, said counterfeiting and smuggling threaten consumer safety, legitimate businesses and national development, requiring stronger policy support and enforcement.

Rajiv Thampula, Additional Commissioner of Customs, Hyderabad Customs, said intelligence-led enforcement and border controls are vital to tackling smuggling net-



works. R. Bhaaskaran, Deputy Inspector General of Police, CI Cell, Intelligence Department, Telangana, stressed greater intelligence sharing and inter-agency collaboration.

T. Muralidharan, Past Chairman, FICCI Telangana State Council, and Chairman, TMI Group, called for collective action by policymakers, industry and consumers. P. C. Jha, Advisor, FICCI CAS-

CADE and former Chairman, CBIC, highlighted technology-driven enforcement and public awareness. A panel chaired by Deep Chand, Advisor, FICCI CASCADE and former Special Commissioner of Police, New Delhi, featured Prof. Bejon Kumar Misra, Founder, Consumer Online Foundation, and Dr. Anant Sharma, National Chairman, Consumer Federation of India.

DRI busts trans-border gold smuggling syndicate, seizes 15 kg smuggled gold

NEW DELHI: The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has busted a trans-border gold smuggling syndicate and seized 15 kg of foreign-origin smuggled gold, valued at Rs 21.40 crore, and arrested four persons, the finance ministry said on Tuesday. Preliminary investigations also reveal that crypto-currency was being used to transfer the money across borders to finance the smuggling, the ministry added.

DRI officers intercepted an international courier consignment originating from Thailand at Courier Terminal, Delhi. The consignment was in the name of a firm linked to a foreign national, the ministry said.

A meticulous examination

of the consignment declared as "worn gear", led to the recovery of eight disc-shaped pieces of foreign-origin gold, each weighing 1.5 kg, ingeniously concealed inside gear parts. In total, 12 kg of smuggled foreign-origin gold was recovered from the courier consignment.

Simultaneous searches conducted at the residence of the intended recipient and the alleged mastermind resulted in the recovery of two more identical disc-shaped pieces of foreign-origin gold, each weighing 1.5 kg.

Four persons, including the mastermind, who is a repeat offender, and a foreign national, have been arrested in relation to the case, the ministry said.

Gold declines ₹800 to ₹1.45 lakh per 10 grams

NEW DELHI: Gold prices eased by Rs 800 to Rs 1.45 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Tuesday amid subdued demand in the domestic market.

According to the All India Sarafa Association, the yellow metal of 99.9 per cent purity declined Rs 800 to Rs 1,45,800 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes) from Monday's closing level of Rs 1,46,600 per 10 grams.

Silver, however, staged a sharp rebound, snapping a four-session losing streak, rising by Rs 6,000 to Rs 2,30,000 per kilogram (inclusive of all taxes). The white metal had settled



at Rs 2,24,000 per kg in the preceding session.

Analysts said gold remained under pressure in the domestic market, while silver attracted value buying after the recent correction. In the international markets, spot gold traded marginally higher at \$4,021.15 per ounce, while silver rose nearly 1 per cent at \$58.81 per ounce.

PFRDA, IAI ink milestone MoU to strengthen pension research and policy collaboration

The MoU was signed at the Joint Conference on Pensions 2026 in New Delhi

NEW DELHI: The Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) and the Institute of Actuaries of India (IAI) on Tuesday signed an MoU to strengthen collaboration in actuarial research, pension policy, technical knowledge exchange and capacity building.

The MoU was signed at the Joint Conference on Pensions 2026 in New Delhi. Dr. V Anantha Nageswaran, Chief Economic Advisor to the Government of India, said India



must build resilient pension systems and ensure simple,

trusted products to expand coverage, particularly in the

informal sector.

S Ramann, Chairperson, PFRDA, said the partnership would support researched innovation in retirement income products. Preeti Chandrashekar, President, IAI, stressed the need for collaborative efforts to address longevity risks, while Ayako Inagaki, Senior Sector Director at the Asian Development Bank (ADB), highlighted India's potential to expand pension inclusion through its digital public infrastructure.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



Bank of Maharashtra, Chandigarh Zone, on Tuesday inaugurated its new branch at Manimajra, Chandigarh, in a dignified ceremony. The branch was inaugurated by Pradhuman Singh (Chief Guest), an officer of the Haryana Civil Service (HCS) in presence of L Rajkishore Patra, Deputy Zonal Manager, Bank of Maharashtra, along with senior bank officials, staff members.



The 62nd Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) Training Programme on "Leadership Skills for Women", sponsored by the Ministry of External Affairs, Government of India, was successfully conducted by Housing and Urban Development Corporation Ltd. (HUDCO) at its HSMI Hostel, Asian Games Village Complex (AGVC), New Delhi, from June 18 to 30, 2026. The valedictory session marked the successful culmination of the programme and was attended by Sanjay Kulshrestha, Chairman & Managing Director, HUDCO; M Nagaraj, Director (Corporate Planning), HUDCO; and Oday Hatim Mohammed, Chargé d'Affaires, Iraq.

US-India trade deal in final steps, says US Ambassador to India Gor

‘Most of this deal is complete. There are a few items that remain on both sides. It’s in the last 1 per cent of that deal,’ Sergio Gor said

WASHINGTON: The US-India trade deal is in its “final steps”, with only the last one per cent of negotiations left to be concluded, US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor said on Tuesday, expressing confidence that the deal would soon be sealed.

Addressing the US-India Strategic Partnership Forum Leadership Summit, Gor said he was determined to agree as it would be beneficial to both nations, and it would be sealed after nearly 18 months of talks.

“We are in the final steps on this deal. Most of this deal is complete. There are a few items that remain on both sides. It’s in the last 1 per cent of that deal,” he said.

The US envoy to India was bullish about the bilateral relationship and cited the personal equation between US President Donald Trump and Prime Minister Narendra Modi, which was driving the ties.

“People ask, Why is this taking so long? We’ve been at this for a year and a half. To put it into perspective, the European



US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor

trade deal took 20 years. So no matter what, as long as we beat the European deal, I think we’re in good shape. But I’m determined to bring this to a close,” he said. The US envoy said the President has very fond memories of his visit to India and still continues to talk about it.

“His (Trump’s) visit last time was one of the most remarkable visits that he continues to talk about. He holds it in a very fond place. It’s an incredible thing.

So, I look forward to having the President visit us back in India,” Gor said.

The ambassador also announced that the Quad foreign ministers are scheduled to meet in the Philippines in about two weeks from now. He added that the agreement would provide greater certainty for businesses engaged in bilateral trade.

“It’s also a deal that, frankly, for a lot of individuals in this

Highlights

» ‘People ask, Why is this taking so long? We’ve been at this for a year and a half. To put it into perspective, the European trade deal took 20 years’

» ‘So no matter what, as long as we beat the European deal, I think we’re in good shape. But I’m determined to bring this to close’

room, brings stability. For those of you that trade bilaterally, it’s something that’s incredibly useful and helpful,” Gor said.

The ambassador said both governments had maintained an intensive pace of negotiations in recent weeks, citing multiple high-level exchanges between trade officials.

“As I mentioned, the trade deal, we’re close to getting it done through very active negotiations. I mean, pretty much

the last three weeks we’ve had travels back and forth. Minister Goyal was in New York... followed by Ambassador Greer in Delhi right afterwards,” he said.

Gor said bilateral trade had already expanded dramatically over the past two decades and was poised for another leap.

“Over the past two decades, our bilateral trade has increased from \$20 billion to \$220 billion. That’s an incredible job, and it’s also something that we’re gonna take to a much higher level,” he said.

He pointed to the ambitious target announced by President Donald Trump and Prime Minister Narendra Modi to increase bilateral trade to \$500 billion.

“What President Trump and Prime Minister Modi announced as a bilateral trade goal of \$500 billion over the next few years, that’s an astounding number that is unmatched,” Gor said. “We are ready to do so much with India. India exports more to the United States than anywhere else by far,” Gor added.

Fiscal deficit at 9.6% of FY27 budget target at May-end: Govt data

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India’s fiscal deficit touched 9.6 per cent of the FY27 budget target at the end of May, government data showed on Tuesday. The fiscal deficit, or gap between the government’s expenditure and revenue, was Rs 1.62 lakh crore in value terms at the end of May 2026, data released by the Controller General of Accounts (CGA) showed.

At the end of May, 2025, the Centre’s fiscal deficit had reduced to 0.8 per cent of the BE of 2025-26 or Rs 13,163 crore. The Centre has set a fiscal deficit target of 4.3 per cent of the GDP or Rs 16.96 lakh crore in the current fiscal. As per the CGA data, net tax receipts stood at Rs 3.48 lakh crore, while non-tax receipts were Rs 3.51 lakh crore. The total expenditure of the central government stood at Rs 8.81 lakh crore at the end of May, including capital expenditure of Rs 2.51 lakh crore.

ICRA Chief Economist Aditi Nayar said the fiscal expansion during April-May was driven by an 18 per cent surge in total expenditure and the 1-2 per cent contraction in net tax receipts and non-tax revenues.

The government’s gross tax revenues rose by a muted 1.8

per cent year-on-year during April-May of FY27, led by the sharp 20 per cent contraction in excise duty collections, following the paring of such duties on petrol and diesel.

Corporate tax collections and customs duty collections posted a strong growth in April-May FY27, even as income tax collections rose by a relatively sluggish 6.8 per cent, much lower than the 17.7 per cent growth required in FY27 to meet the BE for the fiscal.

On the expenditure side, revenue expenditure surged by 20.1 per cent due to a sharp rise in subsidies and interest payments. Capital expenditure expanded by 13.4 per cent during 2M FY2027, which will support GDP growth in the first quarter. “Looking ahead, the sharp dip in global energy prices following the cooling of tensions in West Asia has improved the outlook for the GoI’s fiscal position in FY2027,” Nayar said.

ICRA now expects only a marginal overshooting in the Centre’s fiscal deficit vis-a-vis the target of 4.3 per cent of GDP for FY2027 against the previous estimate of a 40 basis points slippage, which assumed an average crude oil price of \$95/barrel for the fiscal, Nayar added.

OYO parent Prism files DRHP for ₹6,650 cr IPO

NEW DELHI: Travel-tech unicorn Prism, parent of OYO, has filed an updated draft red herring prospectus with Sebi for a Rs 6,650-crore IPO comprising only a fresh issue of shares, with no offer-for-sale component.

The company may also undertake a pre-IPO placement of up to Rs 1,330 crore. SoftBank remains the largest shareholder with a 40.04 per cent stake, while founder Ritesh Agarwal and his entities hold 30.52 per cent.

Prism plans to use about Rs 4,987.5 crore from the issue to repay debt, strengthening its balance sheet. As of December 31, 2025, net borrowings stood at Rs 6,828 crore.

The company posted a net profit of Rs 748.39 crore in the first nine months of FY26 on revenue of Rs 6,940.97 crore, with overseas markets contributing nearly 84 per cent of revenue. Prism had confidentially filed IPO papers in December 2025 after renaming itself from Oravel Stays.

Duty waiver on 40 petchem goods extended till July 15

NEW DELHI: The government on Tuesday extended nil customs duty on the import of 40 critical petrochemical products by 15 days till July 15 to ensure continuity of supply stability amid the West Asia crisis.

The full customs duty waiver on such products provided on April 2 was a “temporary and targeted relief”, and was set to lapse on June 30.

In a statement, the finance ministry said the exemption on April 2 was provided to ensure sufficient availability of petrochemicals in the domestic market as Indian petroleum companies had been asked to concentrate on the production

of LPG during this period. “As the situation is gradually normalising, to ensure a smooth and non-disruptive transition for the affected sectors, it has been decided to extend the said exemption by a further period of 15 days, that is, till July 15, 2026”, it added.

The goods on which the customs duty has been exempted include Methanol, Anhydrous ammonia, Toluene, Styrene, Dichloromethane (methylene chloride), Vinyl chloride monomer, Poly butadiene, Styrene butadiene and Unsaturated polyester resins. “The government remains committed to supporting India’s manufactur-

ing sector,” the ministry said.

As before, the exemption is expected to benefit a wide range of sectors dependent on petrochemical feedstock and intermediates, including plastics, packaging, textiles, pharmaceuticals, chemicals, automotive components and other manufacturing segments. This will also provide relief to consumers of final products, it added.

On April 2, the Finance Ministry had said that in light of the ongoing conflict in West Asia and the consequent disruptions in global supply chains, the government has decided to provide full customs duty exemption on critical petrochemical

products till June 30. This measure was aimed at ensuring the continued availability of critical petrochemical inputs for the domestic industry, reducing cost pressures on downstream sectors, and safeguarding supply stability in the country.

Disruption in shipping routes amid the West Asia war has raised concerns over imports of fertiliser, crude oil and natural gas. India is a major importer of fertiliser and petroleum.

For FY27, the government has set a customs revenue target of Rs 2.71 lakh crore, compared to Rs 2.64 lakh crore in the last fiscal.

After Trent, Noel Tata to step down as Voltas chief

NEW DELHI: Nearly a week after announcing his decision to step down as chairman of Trent, Noel Tata on Tuesday said he would also relinquish the chairmanship of Tata group company Voltas. Addressing shareholders at the company’s 72nd annual general meeting, he said it would be his last AGM as chairman of Voltas.

He said the company had built a strong leadership pipeline through a mix of internal promotions and lateral hiring and expressed confidence that the next generation of leaders would drive growth across all business segments.

Thanking shareholders,



Addressing the firm’s 72nd AGM, Noel Tata said it would be his last AGM as Voltas chairman

employees and business partners for their support over the years, Tata said he was satisfied with the company’s current position and growth trajectory. Highlighting Voltas’ performance, he said the company had entered the new financial year on a strong note, with

its room air conditioner business crossing sales of one million units in a record 81 days, reaffirming its market leadership. He also acknowledged the contribution of employees and joint venture partners.

Tata joined the Voltas board on January 27, 2003, and

became non executive chairman on September 1, 2017, succeeding Ishaat Hussain. He had made a similar announcement during Trent’s annual general meeting on June 23.

Noel Tata, who also chairs Tata Trusts, the largest shareholder of Tata Sons, will turn 70 in November. He has been associated with the Tata group for four decades and currently serves as non executive chairman of Trent, Tata Investment Corporation, Tata International, Trent Hypermarket and Tata International West Asia DMCC. He is also vice chairman of Tata Steel and Titan Company.

Sport

Deja blue for Germany

Familiar feelings for Germany after Paraguay pull off biggest upset so far

FOXBOROUGH: José Canale wasn’t in the starting lineup in either of his previous two appearances for Paraguay in this World Cup. He made his first start a memorable one.

Canale scored on the first sudden-death penalty kick, Orlando Gill made two key saves in the shootout, and Paraguay beat Germany 4-3 on penalties Monday to earn the biggest upset of the 2026 World Cup.

It was a major triumph for the landlocked South American country of 7 million people that’s surrounded by soccer giants like Argentina and Brazil. And it was the latest surprising exit by Germany, a four-time champions that have struggled at the World Cup since they last lifted the trophy in 2014.

“I think we deserved one more game and to be honest, considering everything that was said, everything we went through,” Canale said. “What I want to highlight from our team is how united we are. ... Today was a game we really needed to show our true colors.”

Familiar feeling
Germany should be getting used to disappointment, but it doesn’t make it any less painful for a traditional soccer heavyweight that had been ten-



Germany’s Manuel Neuer walks off as the Paraguayans celebrate winning the shootout

tatively hoping for a fifth World Cup title to restore lost pride.

Germany did manage to survive the group stage for the first time since winning the trophy in 2014, but it’s little consolation after Monday’s loss to unheralded Paraguay on penalties sent the team home after the first knockout game.

“We messed it up,” Joshua Kimmich told reporters after the match in Foxborough, Massachusetts.

It was a familiar feeling for the Germany captain who also struggled for explanations after

1
Paraguay became the first team to defeat Germany in a penalty shootout at the World Cup

the team’s group-stage exit at the 2022 World Cup in Qatar.

Germany coach Julian Nagelsmann is in the firing line after some contentious calls — particularly after recalling veteran goalkeeper Manuel Neuer from international retirement just before the tournament after months of denials.

The 40-year-old Neuer failed to justify his inclusion at the expense of Hoffenheim’s Oliver Baumann, and was arguably at fault for Ecuador’s winning goal in the last group game.

“I gave it my all,” Neuer said.

Son sorry for S Korea’s exit

WASHINGTON: South Korea captain Son Heung-min has apologized for the team’s group-stage exit at the World Cup, saying he is “indiscribably hurt” and eager to “win the hearts” of the nation once again.

In a long post on Instagram on Monday night, Son — a soccer superstar in South Korea and a big name in Major League Soccer with Los Angeles FC — said he understood the disappointment of the team’s fans after its performances in the tournament that have drawn harsh criticism from the country’s president and led to the resignation of coach Hong Myung-bo.

“I don’t dare to convey the disappointment and hurt of the fans with a single word sorry,” Son wrote, “so even saying those words feels insufficient.” “The child’s dream stage” that I always talked about has collapsed,” he added. “I’m indescribably stuck and hurt.”

AGENCIES

Morocco squeeze past Oranje



Morocco’s players celebrate winning the penalty shootout

GUADALUPE: Ismael Saibari scored the decisive goal in a penalty shootout, and Morocco sent the Netherlands to their earliest World Cup exit, eliminating the Dutch 3-2 after a 1-1 draw on Monday night.

With the shootout tied at 2-all after four rounds, Morocco goalkeeper Yassine Bounou made a strong save of Crysencio Summerville’s attempt, batting it away with his left hand. Saibari then sent the winner into the low left corner as goalkeeper Bart Verbruggen went the other direction. The midfielder tore off his shirt and screamed with joy as he was mobbed by teammates.

Earlier in the shootout with Morocco trailing 1-0, Verbruggen appeared to have stopped an attempt by Soufiane Rahimi,

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Morocco’s goal by Issa Diop at 90:05 was their second-latest goal in a FIFA World Cup match

but the goalkeeper couldn’t secure the ball and deflected it over the line with the back of his leg. “We know when we do everything on the pitch, it’s God that gives something back to us as well,” Morocco head coach Mohamed Ouahbi said.

AGENCIES

Gukesh, Pragg lead challenge at Zagreb Rapid and Blitz

ZAGREB: World champion D Gukesh might have taken a sabbatical from classical chess but his commitment to major events remains intact and he will be up against some of the world’s best players in the Zagreb Rapid and Blitz Tournament here on Wednesday.

The event is part of the Grand Chess Tour or GCT, which is the biggest platform to bring together top players. This will be the third event under the GCT brand this year with three more to come.

This event will also feature Indian star R Praggnanandhaa, who is fresh from his victory at the Norway Chess ahead of none other than world No. 1 Magnus Carlsen. The event will feature nine rounds of rapid and 18 rounds of blitz chess.

Each rapid victory will be worth two points and a draw will fetch one point while in blitz, one point will be awarded for a win and a half for a draw.

Gukesh had surprisingly walked out of the GCT citing his recent performances. Despite saying no to main events, Gukesh has committed to playing the rapid and blitz sections as wildcard. For Praggnanandhaa what remains to be seen is his proficiency in the faster version.

AGENCIES

Emotional Swiatek digs deep; Rybakina survives

LONDON: Defending champion Iga Swiatek overcame a seiga second-set wobble to reach the second round at Wimbledon on Tuesday, beating powerful American Taylor Townsend 6-1 2-6 6-3.

Swiatek, 25, a former world No. 1 with six Grand Slam titles under her belt, looked to be cruising when she broke nervy 30-year-old Townsend’s serve twice in the first set and took it with a stylish forehand winner.



But it was the third seed’s

turn to suffer nerves in the second set. She sprayed groundstrokes long and wide as her forehand consistency deserted her and the 79th-ranked Townsend capitalised, breaking serve twice and capturing the set with an exquisite backhand drop volley and an ace.

Second seed Elena Rybakina survived a first round scare against French debutant Lois Boisson to grind out an unconvincing 6-4 1-6 6-3 win.

Boisson, who enjoyed a fairytale run to the French Open semi-finals last year but was knocked out in the first round this year, was helped by an error-strewn performance by the Russian-born Kazakh ranked 152 places above her.

“It was a really difficult match, also not coming from too many wins. I had to really fight,” said the reigning Australian Open champion.

AGENCIES

PREVENTIVE HEALTHCARE TAKES CENTRE STAGE

Illness to Wellness Foundation marks National Doctors' Day

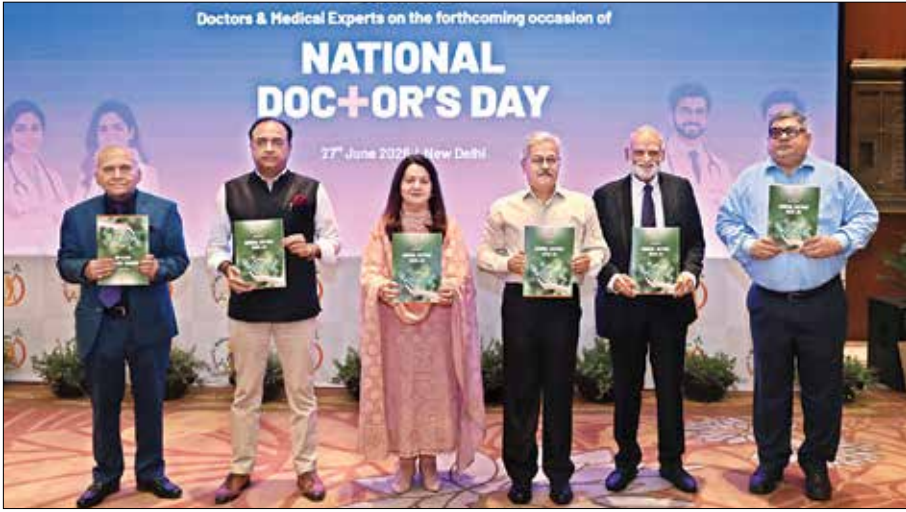
Experts at the Illness to Wellness Foundation programme stress early screening, healthier lifestyles and preventive healthcare to reduce India's growing disease burden

OUR CORRESPONDENT

As India observes National Doctors Day, the Illness to Wellness Foundation organised a special programme that brought together a distinguished gathering of healthcare leaders, senior doctors and eminent members of the medical fraternity. The event recognised the invaluable contribution of doctors in safeguarding public health and reaffirmed the importance of preventive healthcare in reducing India's growing disease burden. The Foundation expressed its heartfelt gratitude to these silent heroes whose unwavering commitment to humanity continues to inspire hope and build a healthier, stronger and more resilient nation.

The programme was also attended by diplomats from countries such as Sri Lanka, New Zealand, Ireland and Jordan, reflecting the growing global interest in India's preventive healthcare initiatives. It also witnessed the participation of leading media organisations including NDTV, Aaj Tak, ETV Bharat, PTI, CNN News 18, Mint, NewsX, The Statesman, Nav Bharat Times, Dainik Jagran, Dainik Bhaskar, Punjab Kesari, The Pioneer, The Millennium Post, BW Healthcare, IANS and others. The event also brought together policymakers, industry leaders, academicians, researchers and wellness experts from across the country, fostering a meaningful dialogue on strengthening preventive healthcare and improving public health outcomes.

During the occasion, the Illness to Wellness Annual Report 2025-26 was also unveiled. The report was released by Rajesh Bhusan, Former Secretary, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India and Chairperson, Governing Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation; Prof. Nirmal



Kumar Ganguly, Former Director General, Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) and Member, Governing Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation; Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation; Kiran Chopra, Director, Punjab Kesari; Prashant Tiwari, CMD, Opinion Express and Editorial Member, 'The Pioneer' and Durbar Ganguly, Editor-in-Chief, 'Millennium Post'.

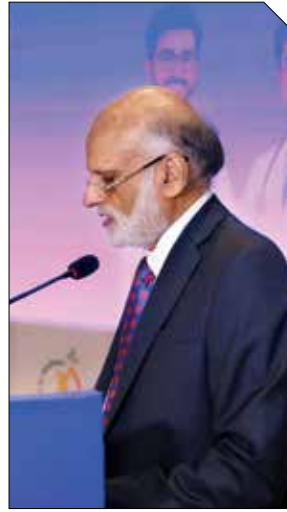
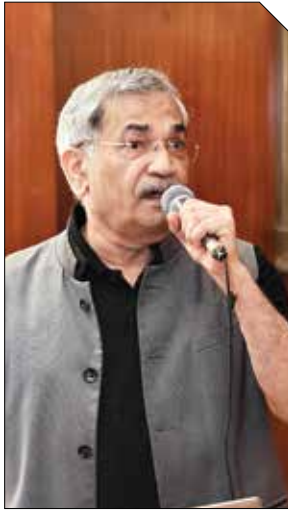
The Annual Report 2025-26 highlights the Foundation's year-long efforts to advance preventive healthcare through health awareness campaigns, community outreach programmes, school health initiatives, workplace wellness interventions and preventive health screen-

ing drives across the country. During the year, the Foundation collaborated with leading healthcare experts and institutions to promote early diagnosis, healthier lifestyles and behavioural change, while supporting national public health initiatives such as the TB Mukh Bharat Abhiyan and Swachh Bharat Mission through awareness and community engagement activities. The report also outlines the Foundation's continued focus on integrating physical, mental and nutritional well-being to build a culture in which wellness becomes a way of life rather than a response to illness.

Rajesh Bhusan, Former Secretary, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India and Chairperson, Gov-

erning Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, said, "India has made significant strides in expanding access to healthcare and strengthening its treatment infrastructure. The next phase of our healthcare journey must focus equally on prevention. A prevention-first approach, supported by regular screening, early diagnosis, healthier lifestyles and greater public awareness, can substantially reduce the burden of both communicable and non-communicable diseases. Preventive healthcare is not only a public health priority, but also an economic imperative for building a healthier and more productive nation."

Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, said, "As



DURING THE OCCASION, THE ILLNESS TO WELLNESS ANNUAL REPORT 2025-26 WAS ALSO UNVEILED

healthcare evolves, the role of doctors continues to expand - from treating illness to advancing wellness, from responding to disease to encouraging prevention. Doctors today are not only healers; they are educators, mentors and trusted guides who empower individuals and communities to lead healthier lives. This belief lies at the heart of the Illness to Wellness Foundation. We believe that the future of healthcare must focus not only on curing disease, but also on building a culture of well-being. A healthier society cannot be created through hospitals and medicines alone. It requires awareness, prevention, healthier lifestyles and a shared commitment to wellness."

Prof. (Dr) Nirmal Kumar

Ganguly, Former Director General, Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR) and Member, Governing Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, shared, "One of the biggest health challenges India faces today is the growing burden of obesity, which is the root cause of many major non-communicable diseases. Preventive healthcare is the most effective way to address both communicable and non-communicable diseases. Adopting a healthier lifestyle through regular exercise, yoga, meditation, a balanced diet rich in fruits, vegetables and fibre, along with adequate rest, can significantly improve long-term health outcomes. Unfortunately, very few Indians proactively seek preventive healthcare. We need to create

greater awareness and encourage people to understand that prevention is far more important than waiting for illness to occur. It can also help delay accelerated ageing and reduce the risk of several age-related conditions."

Prof. (Dr) G C Khilnani, Chairman, PSRI Institute of Pulmonary, Critical Care & Sleep Medicine and Former Professor & Head, Department of Pulmonary Medicine & Sleep Disorders, AIIMS, New Delhi, said, "If preventive healthcare becomes a way of life, a large proportion of lifestyle and seasonal diseases can be prevented. Prevention is always more effective than a cure. Regular health check-ups, balanced nutrition, physical activity, vaccination where appropriate, good hygiene and timely medi-

cal consultation are simple yet powerful interventions that can significantly reduce disease burden and improve quality of life."

Yash Gulati, Padma Shri, Senior Consultant Orthopaedic and Joint Replacement Surgeon, Apollo Hospitals, New Delhi, added, "Mobility is one of the greatest indicators of healthy ageing. The sooner we begin caring for our bones, joints and muscles, the healthier our future will be. If a child starts practising yoga and remains physically active from an early age, many mobility-related problems can be prevented later in life. As doctors, we must encourage people to view preventive healthcare not as an occasional health check-up, but as a lifelong commitment to healthy living. Every step taken towards prevention today reduces the burden of disease tomorrow."

The Illness to Wellness Foundation has consistently advocated a shift from illness-centred healthcare towards a wellness-oriented ecosystem by promoting preventive healthcare, early intervention, community engagement and behavioural change. Through health awareness initiatives, school health programmes, workplace wellness campaigns, community outreach and health screening programmes, the Foundation continues to encourage individuals to adopt healthier lifestyles and take proactive responsibility for their well-being.

Experts unanimously agreed that while India's healthcare ecosystem has made significant advances in expanding access to quality treatment, the next phase of healthcare transformation must be driven by prevention. By empowering citizens to make informed lifestyle choices, encouraging regular health screenings and leveraging technology alongside trusted medical guidance, India can build a healthier future where wellness becomes a way of life rather than a response to illness.

RAJWADA RANG

A royal celebration of Rajasthan's culinary heritage

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Experience the grandeur, flavours and traditions of Rajasthan as Holiday Inn New Delhi Mayur Vihar Noida is hosting 'Rajwada Rang', a specially curated Rajasthani food festival at Café on 3 till July 4, 2026, between 7 pm and 11 pm.

With Café on 3 transformed into a vibrant Rajasthani setting, the venue is adorned with traditional décor, colourful accents and cultural elements that evoke the charm of Rajasthan, creating an immersive dining experience for guests.

The festival is thoughtfully curated by Executive Chef Ashutosh Bisht in collaboration with Guest Chef Hem Singh Gurjar from Holiday Inn Jaipur City Centre. A native of Rajasthan, Chef Hem brings with him generations of culinary knowledge and an intimate understanding of the state's rich food traditions. His expertise and deep-rooted connection to the cuisine ensure that guests experience the authentic recipes, flavours and aromas of the desert state.

The gastronomic journey begins with traditional soups such as the nourishing 'Bajre Ki Raab' and the robust 'Mutton Paya Ka Raab', offering guests a taste of Rajasthan's rustic culinary roots. The expe-



rience continues with an array of appetisers including 'Paneer Rajwada', 'Kadai Ki Seekh', 'Jaipuri Tangri Kebab' and 'Jaisalmeri Murg Malai Roll', each crafted to highlight the region's distinctive spices and cooking techniques.

For the main course, diners can indulge in an elaborate spread featuring beloved classics such as 'Rajasthani Kadhi', 'Dal Marwadi', 'Gatte Ki Curry' and the unique 'Gulab Jamun Ki Sabzi'. Non-vegetarian specialities including the fiery 'Laal Maas' and flavourful 'Mutton Banjara' bring the bold essence

of Rajasthan's royal kitchens to the table. Accompaniments such as freshly prepared 'Bajra Ki Roti' and traditional 'Churma' complete the feast.

The culinary voyage concludes on a sweet note with iconic Rajasthani desserts including 'Ghewar Malai', 'Alwar Ka Milk Cake' and 'Mawa Kachori' showcasing the region's celebrated dessert traditions.

Speaking about the festival, Ashutosh Bisht, Executive Chef, Holiday Inn New Delhi Mayur Vihar Noida, said, "Rajwada Rang" is an ode to Rajasthan's rich culinary legacy. By partnering with Chef Hem Singh Gurjar, we have curated a menu that stays true to authentic flavours while offering guests a memorable and immersive dining experience. Every dish tells a story of tradition, culture and the royal heritage of Rajasthan."

Adding to this, Shashi Shankar, Food & Beverage Manager, said, "Beyond the food, 'Rajwada Rang' is about recreating the spirit of Rajasthan. From the vibrant décor to the carefully crafted menu, every element has been designed to transport guests to the royal heartland of India and offer them an unforgettable culinary journey."

For reservations and enquiries, please contact +91 8860634424

'INCREDIBLY HUMBLING AND DEEPLY FULFILLING'

Sharvari is overwhelmed with the response to 'Main Vaapas Aaunga'

Sharvari, who is overwhelmed with the response to 'Main Vaapas Aaunga', hopes the audience gives similar love to her new film 'Alpha'.

In the Imtiaz Ali-directed film, Sharvari played the role of Jiya opposite Vedang Raina's Keenu. Set against the backdrop of Partition, the film has witnessed a remarkable turnaround at the box office purely because of word of mouth and has now crossed Rs 50 crore at the box office.

Sharvari credited Ali for all the love coming her way for her performance in the movie. "I've honestly been overwhelmed by the love that 'Main Vaapas Aaunga' is receiving from all quarters. As an actor, you dream of being part of stories that connect with people deeply and seeing audiences appreciate my performance so wholeheartedly is incredibly humbling and deeply fulfilling," she said.

She added, "I'm grateful to Imtiaz Ali sir for this huge moment in my career. I feel all the credit for the success of 'Main Vaapas Aaunga' belongs to him. As a captain of the ship, his vision and his passion for this heartfelt story have resonated with people across the country. I'm eternally grateful to him for believing in me and to everyone who has watched this special film and embraced it with so much warmth. Moments like these remind me why I fell in love with movies and acting: cinema can spread so much joy and connect us as humans."

The actress, who is now set to feature in 'Alpha' alongside Alia Bhatt, hopes her next project receives a positive response from the audience. "I sincerely hope it continues to be special as I'm also rooting for my film 'Alpha', she said. PTI



She said that she hopes the audience gives similar love to her new film 'Alpha'

There's liberation in it: Olivia

Wilde on 'Don't Worry Darling' scoring 38 per cent 'Rotten Tomatoes' score

Filmmaker and actress Olivia Wilde said the 38 per cent 'Rotten Tomatoes' score on her 2022 film 'Don't Worry Darling' was "liberating" and led her to make her latest directorial, 'The Invite'.

'The Invite', which was released on June 26, featured Wilde alongside Seth Rogen and Penelope Cruz. It revolves around an exhausted couple, Joe (Seth Rogen) and Angela (Wilde), who invite their

The filmmaker-actress said she embraced the failure of the project

vibrant, upstairs neighbours, Hawk (Edward Norton) and Pina (Penelope Cruz), over for a dinner party while their tween daughter is away.

The film was shot in 21 days in story order and marked her

third directorial. The entire premise of the film is confined to a single San Francisco apartment, which allowed her to rehearse it like a play, according to the entertainment news outlet 'Variety'.

"Every distributor wanted to take this movie to theatres and I was adamant that we didn't go to a streamer. Of all the non-streamers, they all wanted to put it in a theatre. That's a really good sign for everyone," Wilde told the outlet. PTI

